

Before the Name

Book Two of the Undiscovered Witch Series

Jessica Braden

ISBN: 9798243121279

Independently published

Copyright © Jessica Braden

All rights reserved.

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places, and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or used fictitiously.

Chapter 1 — Residual Calm

Allison's Notes (saved, then immediately minimized):

- Things that didn't happen today:
- The hallway argument didn't turn into yelling.
- Someone almost dropped a phone — didn't.
- It felt like the moment... chose the easier version.

Allison stared at the list for a beat too long.

It was short. It was stupid. It was the kind of note she'd normally delete, the way she deleted everything that sounded dramatic when written down. She could already hear her own internal voice mocking it—*Congratulations, you noticed people didn't scream today.*

But the cursor blinked like it was waiting for her to be honest.

She wasn't ready.

So she minimized the note and shoved her phone into her hoodie pocket like the screen had burned her.

The cafeteria smelled like fries and disinfectant and that weird sweet-sour scent that clung to plastic trays no matter how often they washed them. It was loud in a way that always made Allison feel like she was listening to a single sound instead of many—voices layering into one steady roar, chairs scraping, laughter

cutting through like sharp little whistles.

Senior year had turned the whole building restless.

People moved like they were late even when they weren't. Like time was running out and no one wanted to admit they could feel it.

At lunch, Kara slid into the seat across from her like the day belonged to her.

"You look like you slept in a dryer," Kara said, unkindly. "Senior year is eating you alive."

Allison managed a small smile and let Kara's certainty fill the space she didn't know how to explain.

Kara was already talking about something—college emails, a teacher who was apparently "on one today," a fight in the parking lot that had been broken up before it became a video. Kara's hands moved when she talked, slicing the air like she could cut stress in half if she gestured hard enough.

Allison nodded in the right places. She laughed when Kara laughed. She took bites of her food because her hands needed something to do.

Normal.

That was the goal. That was always the goal.

Kara paused mid-sentence, squinting at Allison like she was solving a puzzle. "Okay, no. Seriously. What's with you?"

Allison's throat tightened automatically.

Nothing is wrong. Nothing is happening.

She forced her shoulders to stay loose. "I'm fine."

Kara made a face. "That's not an answer, that's a politician's statement."

Allison's smile twitched. "I'm tired."

"That," Kara said, pointing at her like she'd won something, "is an answer. A depressing one, but an answer."

Allison let the conversation roll on because Kara wouldn't let it stop. Kara hated silence the way some people hated fluorescent lights. She filled emptiness instinctively, like she couldn't stand the idea of a space that might echo.

Allison loved her for it.

And sometimes, lately, Allison hated how easy Kara made everything look.

The first thing Allison noticed today was what **didn't** happen.

It started between third and fourth period, when the hallway near the science wing always turned into a clogged river of bodies. Everyone moved in uneven clumps, shoulder to shoulder, backpacks smacking into lockers. The air was warmer there—stale from too many people, too many layers, too much perfume and gym sweat and cheap body spray.

Allison was halfway through the crowd when she felt it.

That tightening.

The change in the air before a moment tipped.

Voices rose near the corner by the trophy case—two girls, both talking too fast, both sharp with that particular kind of cruelty that came from being watched. There were boys nearby, laughing a little too loudly, leaning like they wanted front-row seats. Someone's phone was already out, angled casually, the way people pretended it wasn't recording until later.

Allison didn't know the names. She didn't need to.

She knew the shape of the moment.

She felt it coming before she saw it—the familiar tightening in her chest that meant something was about to spill. Like her body had learned the warning signs the way it learned the sound of a storm.

It was the same feeling she got when she heard someone's tone shift from teasing to mean. When a joke stopped being funny and became a weapon. When a laugh started to bite.

Allison slowed her steps.

Not consciously. Just enough to be there.

The two girls squared up the way people did when they wanted to look brave. Faces angled, shoulders up, hands doing that restless thing where they weren't sure what to do with themselves. The crowd thickened around them, hungry.

One of the girls said something Allison didn't catch—too much noise, too much echo—but the other one flinched, and that flinch made everything sharpen. It turned the moment from *argument* into *incident*.

Allison's pulse spiked.

Here it comes.

She hated that she could predict it. Hated that she could feel it like pressure under her skin.

And then—

Nothing.

Not nothing like the world stopped.

Nothing like... the world chose a different line.

The words that should have landed hard... didn't.

The first girl's voice lifted, ready to crest into yelling. You could hear the breath before the scream, the inhalation that was going to make it bigger.

But the breath came out in a scoff instead.

Not a scream. Not a sob. Not a shove.

Just a scoff.

Like she'd lost her own momentum.

Someone laughed—one of the boys, probably expecting it to be cruel—but the laugh came out wrong and faded immediately, as if it hadn't found the reaction it needed to survive.

The second girl's shoulders dropped a fraction. Her face stayed guarded, but the moment didn't bite down on her the way it should have.

A phone slipped from someone's hand—Allison saw it flash as it tipped, screen catching the fluorescent light—and it should have hit the tile. It should have cracked. It should have sparked that quick, ugly excitement people got when something broke in public.

But someone's fingers closed around it before it fell.

Too fast. Too clean.

The tension thinned, stretched, and dissolved like it had lost interest in existing.

People moved on.

Not because a teacher appeared. Not because someone intervened. Not because anyone did anything heroic or dramatic.

Just... because the moment didn't hold.

Allison stood there longer than necessary, her pulse still racing for a threat that never arrived.

She should have felt relief.

Relief was the normal reaction.

Instead she felt cold.

Not fear. Not panic.

Recognition.

Because this wasn't the first time.

It wasn't even the fifth.

This had been happening more often lately. Not dramatically. Not in ways anyone could point to. Just little things that failed to escalate. Moments that should have broken sharp instead smoothing out, quietly, as if the world itself had chosen the easier path.

It wasn't like she was walking around making people nice.

That wasn't how it felt.

It felt more like... the worst version of something kept not happening near her.

Like she was a gravity well, but for conflict.

Like the air around her favored softer outcomes.

And if she was imagining it, why did her body react like it was real?

Allison forced her feet to move. She threaded through the rest of the crowd with her head down, shoulders tucked, trying to shrink herself the way she always had when attention got dangerous.

She told herself it was coincidence.

She told herself she was tired.

She told herself stress made patterns out of nothing.

But her hands were shaking by the time she reached her locker.

She fumbled the combination once, then again. The numbers blurred. Her heart wouldn't slow down because it had already decided something bad was supposed to happen and now it didn't know where to put the adrenaline.

She leaned her forehead against the cool metal and closed her eyes.

Stop it, she told herself. **Stop making it a thing.**

Her phone buzzed in her pocket—some group chat, probably—and she didn't check it. She didn't want new information. She didn't want proof of anything, even accidentally.

She just wanted one day where the world didn't feel like it was waiting for her to do something.

When she finally walked to class, the air around her felt... settled.

It was subtle. If she wasn't paying attention, she might not have noticed it. It wasn't a hum or a glow or some fantasy-movie signal that the universe had chosen her.

It was calmer in the way a room felt after someone decided not to slam the door.

Like the echo of something that had already passed through.

Allison kept her eyes forward. She held her books tighter to her chest as if weight could anchor her. She took measured breaths and focused on ordinary details—the poster peeling off the wall, the gum stuck

under the ledge of the water fountain, the way someone's laughter bounced too loud off the ceiling tiles.

Normal.

Normal.

Normal.

But underneath it all, the thought wouldn't leave her alone:

If the worst versions of moments kept not happening...

What did that mean about her?

And worse—what did it mean if she could tell?

She pushed open the classroom door and slid into her seat like she belonged there.

Like she was just another exhausted senior trying to survive the year.

Like she wasn't walking around carrying a string of events that didn't happen, trailing behind her like invisible evidence.

Her phone buzzed again.

Allison didn't look.

She kept her hands flat on the desk, palms down, as if she could hold the world in place by refusing to move.

And somewhere in the back of her mind, the minimized note waited—small, stupid, and impossible to unwrite.

Things that didn't happen today.

Things that should have.

Things that didn't.

Things that didn't... because of her.

Or because of something near her that she didn't have words for yet.

She swallowed, forced her face neutral, and stared at the board as the teacher began to speak.

The day continued.

And the calm did too.

Chapter 2 — Aftershocks

Allison didn't dream.

That was the first thing she noticed when she woke up.

Usually there were fragments—half-formed images, conversations that dissolved when she tried to hold onto them, the vague sense that she'd been somewhere else and come back without souvenirs. Even bad dreams left something behind: a tight chest, a lingering mood, the echo of adrenaline.

This morning there was nothing.

She opened her eyes and stared at the ceiling fan turning slowly above her bed, each rotation identical to the last. The room felt settled in a way she couldn't remember experiencing before, like the air had already decided what kind of day it was going to be.

Quiet. Neutral. Empty.

That should have been comforting.

Instead it made her uneasy.

She lay still longer than usual, listening. The house made its normal sounds—the low hum of the refrigerator downstairs, pipes ticking faintly in the walls, the distant bark of a dog somewhere on the street. Everything was where it was supposed to be.

No tension. No sense of waiting.

Her phone buzzed on the nightstand, face down. Allison didn't reach for it right away.

She'd started doing that lately—delaying small things, as if putting off information could keep it from solidifying. Messages, notifications, updates. Proof that the world was continuing without her permission.

Eventually she flipped the phone over.

A text from Kara, sent late the night before.

> you alive

>

> also don't forget we have that stupid history thing today

>

> wear something that doesn't scream "i gave up"

Allison huffed a quiet laugh despite herself. The sound felt strange in the stillness of her room, like she'd disturbed something.

She typed back:

> noted

>

> no promises

Kara responded immediately with a skull emoji and a threat involving eyeliner.

Normal.

She sat up and swung her legs over the side of the bed. The carpet was cool against her feet. She paused there, waiting for the familiar rush of thoughts—the replaying of yesterday, the spiral of what ifs that usually greeted her mornings.

It didn't come.

Her head felt... clear.

Too clear.

Allison frowned and stood, pulling on a hoodie even though the room wasn't cold. She liked the weight of it, the way it created a boundary between her and everything else.

Downstairs, her mom was already in the kitchen, moving around with the distracted efficiency of someone who'd been awake for hours. The radio murmured softly on the counter, a morning show host laughing at something Allison couldn't quite hear.

"Morning," her mom said without turning around.

"Morning."

Her mom glanced over then, eyes sharpening in that way parents had when they were scanning for problems. "You okay?"

Allison hesitated.

It was such a simple question. One she'd answered a thousand times with automatic lies. Fine. Tired. Just school.

“I think so,” she said instead.

Her mom studied her for another second, then nodded.
“Good. Eat something.”

Allison poured cereal into a bowl and sat at the table, the spoon clinking softly against ceramic. The mundane sounds felt amplified, like the house was paying attention to itself.

As she ate, she waited for something to go wrong.

The milk didn’t spill. The spoon didn’t slip from her fingers. The radio didn’t crackle into static.

Nothing disrupted the rhythm of the morning.

By the time she grabbed her backpack and headed out the door, the unease had settled into her bones.

The walk to school felt longer than usual, though nothing about it had changed. Same cracked sidewalk. Same row of mailboxes. Same tree near the corner with the low branch she always ducked under.

She passed a couple arguing quietly near a parked car. Their voices were tight, clipped. Allison felt that now-familiar tightening in her chest—

And then it loosened.

The argument fizzled before it could crest. One of them sighed, rubbed their face, and the moment dissolved into something tired instead of sharp.

Allison kept walking.

Her pace slowed without her meaning it to.

Coincidence, she told herself. You're projecting.

At school, the hallways buzzed with the usual morning chaos. Lockers slammed. Someone laughed too loud. Someone else swore under their breath when they dropped a stack of papers.

Allison threaded through it, hyperaware.

A near-collision in front of her resolved into an awkward sidestep instead of an apology-fueled glare. A raised voice dropped before it could turn into a challenge. Even the usual tension near the stairwell—the spot where people always bottlenecked—felt muted.

Like the building itself was exhaling.

Kara found her by their lockers, already mid-complaint. "I swear, if Mr. Henson assigns one more 'reflection' —"

She stopped short when she saw Allison's face. "Okay. That look again. What is that?"

Allison blinked. "What look?"

"The one where you're somewhere else," Kara said. "Like you're trying to hear something no one else can."

Allison swallowed. "I'm just tired."

Kara narrowed her eyes. "You said that yesterday."

"And it was true yesterday."

“And today?”

Allison opened her mouth, then closed it.

“I don’t know,” she admitted.

Kara stared at her for a beat, then shrugged. “Senior year is messing with all of us. You’re allowed to be weird.”

She bumped Allison’s shoulder lightly, grounding her. Allison let out a breath she hadn’t realized she’d been holding.

History class blurred past. Allison took notes automatically, her handwriting neat but detached. She noticed things she usually wouldn’t—the way the teacher paused before calling on students, the subtle shifts in posture when people were about to interrupt each other.

Every time she braced for tension, it... eased.

Not vanished. Just softened.

By the time the bell rang, her head was buzzing.

In the bathroom between classes, she locked herself into a stall and leaned back against the door, breathing slowly. She pressed her palms against her thighs, grounding herself in the physicality of it.

This is nothing, she told herself. You’re noticing patterns because you’re looking for them.

But the truth pressed uncomfortably close:

She hadn't been looking.

The patterns had found her.

When she pulled out her phone, the Notes app was still minimized. The list waited behind a single tap.

She didn't open it.

She couldn't decide what scared her more—that adding to it would make it real, or that not adding to it would feel like lying.

By the end of the day, Allison was exhausted in a way that had nothing to do with schoolwork.

It wasn't physical tiredness. It was the strain of constant restraint, of bracing for something that refused to arrive.

As she walked home, the sky hung low and gray, threatening rain that never quite fell. The air felt heavy, charged.

A storm that couldn't decide whether to break.

Allison stopped at the edge of the street and watched cars pass, her reflection faint in their windows. She looked like herself. Same hoodie. Same messy hair. Same girl who'd spent years trying not to stand out.

And yet—

Something about the space around her felt... responsive.

Like the world was listening.

The thought made her stomach twist.

She crossed the street quickly, as if movement could outrun it, and didn't slow until she reached her front door.

Inside, the house was quiet again.

Safe. Predictable.

She kicked off her shoes and leaned back against the door, closing her eyes.

This can't be happening, she thought.

Because if it was—

Then yesterday hadn't been an accident.

And if yesterday hadn't been an accident...

Allison opened her eyes and stared at the empty hallway.

For the first time, the calm didn't feel neutral.

It felt deliberate.

And she didn't know what that meant yet—but she knew one thing with unsettling clarity:

Whatever this was, it wasn't done with her.

Not even close.

Chapter 3 — Close Enough to Notice

Emily noticed before Allison said anything.

She always did.

They were walking together after school, cutting through the side street instead of taking the longer route past the shops. The pavement was damp from earlier rain, darkened in uneven patches that reflected the dull gray sky. Leaves clung to the curb in soggy piles, crushed and half-rotted, the smell of wet earth rising every time a car passed.

Allison liked this route because it felt quieter. Less watched. Like the town wasn't paying as much attention here.

Emily liked it because it gave her time to think.

They'd been walking this way together for years. Long enough that silence between them wasn't something to solve. It was just part of the rhythm—footsteps, breath, the soft scuff of shoes on concrete. Allison usually relaxed into it without thinking.

Today, she didn't.

She could feel Emily beside her in that way you only felt people who knew you too well. Emily didn't crowd her, didn't look at her directly, but her presence pressed gently at Allison's awareness all the same.

Allison found herself cataloging small things she normally wouldn't: the way Emily's steps matched

hers, the way she slowed automatically when Allison did, the way she tilted her head slightly as if listening for something beneath the noise of the street.

That was when Emily spoke.

“You’re different,” she said.

The word hit Allison like a sudden change in elevation.

Her foot caught on a crack in the sidewalk and she stumbled half a step before catching herself. Her heart spiked, sharp and immediate, like it had been waiting for permission.

“What?” she asked, too fast.

Emily glanced over, one eyebrow lifting. “Wow. Okay. That reaction alone answers half my question.”

Allison forced herself to slow down. She matched Emily’s pace deliberately, like control could be reasserted through effort. “Different how?”

Emily shrugged, but it was a careful movement. Noncommittal. “I don’t know. You’re steadier. Like you’re bracing for something and then realizing you don’t have to.”

“That makes no sense.”

“It does if you’re paying attention.”

Allison scoffed quietly and kicked a pebble ahead of them. It bounced once, twice, then vanished into a storm drain with a hollow clink.

“You’ve been hanging out with Kara too much,” she said. “She’s rubbing off on you.”

Emily snorted. “Please. Kara would’ve already diagnosed you and tried to fix it with eyeliner and caffeine.”

A small smile flickered between them, familiar and brief.

But it didn’t settle.

Silence followed for another block. Not awkward. Just... weighted.

Emily had always been like this. She let quiet do work instead of rushing to fill it. As kids, it used to drive Allison crazy. Now it made her nervous in a different way.

Because Allison could feel herself resisting the urge to talk.

She knew, instinctively, that if she started explaining—anything—she’d lose control of where the words went. She didn’t know how much she could say before Emily started connecting dots Allison wasn’t ready to see connected.

Emily broke the quiet again, gently.

“Did something happen?”

The answer rose immediately, reflexive and practiced.

No.

Allison swallowed it.

“I don’t think so,” she said instead.

Emily hummed under her breath. “That’s an interesting way to say no.”

Allison’s fingers curled tighter around the strap of her backpack. The fabric dug into her palm, grounding her. “Nothing big. Just... school. Everything feels weird lately.”

“Senior year weird,” Emily said.

“Yeah.”

Emily nodded, but her gaze stayed forward, unfocused, like she was replaying something she hadn’t quite finished thinking through.

They reached the stretch where the street narrowed, sidewalks drawing closer together as if the neighborhood itself were leaning in. A car came down the road too fast, engine whining, tires hissing against damp pavement.

Allison felt it before she could stop herself.

That tightening. That subtle pull under her ribs. The certainty that the moment was about to tip into something sharp and loud and out of her control.

Her body reacted on instinct. She slowed without meaning to, shoulders tensing, breath catching in preparation for impact.

The car slowed too.

Brake lights flared red against the gray afternoon. The engine downshifted. It rolled to a controlled stop at the light instead of blasting through it.

The moment dissolved.

Allison let out a breath she hadn't realized she'd been holding.

The air felt different immediately afterward—smoother, quieter, like a surface that had just been wiped clean.

Emily frowned.

“Did you feel that?” she asked.

Allison's stomach dropped.

“Feel what?”

Emily didn't answer right away. Her eyes tracked the car as it waited at the light, then flicked back to Allison—not accusing, not curious in a sharp way. Thoughtful.

“Like something almost happened,” Emily said slowly. “And then didn't.”

Allison forced a laugh, brittle and thin. “You mean the car?”

“Yes,” Emily said. “But not just that.”

Rain began again, light and misty. They kept walking, shoulders nearly brushing now. Allison was acutely aware of every step, every breath, every shift of weight.

“You’ve been flinching,” Emily said softly. “And then relaxing. Like you’re bracing for things that don’t happen.”

Allison’s pulse thudded in her ears.

She could feel herself being observed—not just her words, but the timing of her reactions, the way tension moved through her body and then released.

She wanted to deny it. To joke. To tell Emily she was imagining things.

But Emily wasn’t imagining.

And Emily didn’t push when she sensed resistance.

“I think I’m just stressed,” Allison said carefully.
“Everything feels... on edge.”

Emily nodded, eyes forward again. “Okay.”

Not agreement.

Acknowledgment.

They walked the rest of the way home together in silence. Not awkward. Just full.

The calm followed them.

Allison could feel it the way you felt humidity before a storm—subtle, pervasive, impossible to ignore once you noticed it. Cars slowed. A dog barking in a nearby yard quieted after one sharp sound. Even the rain seemed to thin as they reached their street.

Their house came into view, familiar and ordinary.
Allison usually felt relief at the sight of it.

Today, the relief didn't come.

Inside, the quiet felt heavier than outside had. The kind of quiet that settled into corners and waited.

Emily kicked off her shoes and dropped her bag by the stairs. Allison did the same, movements automatic. Neither of them spoke.

Emily glanced at her once, then looked away.

She didn't ask anything else.

That might have been the worst part.

Because it meant Emily had noticed—and decided to wait.

Allison retreated to her room a few minutes later, shutting the door softly behind her. She leaned back against it, listening to the familiar sounds of home: the hum of the fridge, the distant clink of dishes, Emily moving somewhere downstairs.

The calm slipped in after her.

Not dramatic. Not overwhelming.

Just present.

Allison slid down until she was sitting on the floor, knees pulled to her chest.

Emily was close enough now.

Close enough to feel when things didn't behave the way they should.

And Allison couldn't pretend anymore that this was something she could keep to herself.

She pulled out her phone, hesitated, then opened the Notes app.

The list was longer now.

Allison's Notes — do not delete:

- Emily noticed. Not everything, but enough.

- She didn't push. That might be worse.

- She felt the car slow too. Or she felt me feel it.

- If Emily can tell when things almost happen...

- Then this isn't just happening around me anymore.

Allison stared at the last line until the words blurred.

Then she locked her phone and set it face down on the floor beside her.

The calm remained.

Chapter 4 — Held in Place

The first time Allison noticed it with a teacher, she almost missed it.

It was small. Smaller than the hallway moments, smaller than the car slowing, smaller even than Emily's pause. It happened in English class, halfway through a discussion that had already gone off the rails.

They were supposed to be talking about symbolism. Instead, two students in the back had started sniping at each other—quiet at first, voices sharp but contained, the way people spoke when they wanted an audience but not consequences. Chairs shifted. Someone laughed too loudly. A phone appeared, angled low.

Allison felt the shift before anyone raised their voice.

That tightening. That familiar internal brace, like her body was preparing for noise.

She lowered her eyes to her notebook, pen hovering over half-finished notes. She could already picture how this usually went: a warning too late, a reprimand that escalated things, the rest of the class simmering in resentment.

Mr. Lang cleared his throat.

Once.

The sound wasn't loud. It wasn't even particularly commanding. It was the kind of noise teachers made when they were deciding whether to intervene or let

something play out.

But the argument stopped.

Not slowed. Not redirected.

Stopped.

The two students went quiet like they'd reached the end of a sentence they hadn't meant to finish. One blinked, genuinely confused, then looked back down at their book. The phone disappeared without comment.

Mr. Lang didn't raise his voice. He didn't scold. He just continued talking, seamlessly, like nothing had happened.

The room followed.

Desks creaked as people resettled. Pages turned. The low buzz of tension drained away.

Allison stared at her notes, pen still unmoving.

That shouldn't have worked.

She'd seen teachers try that exact move before—soft authority, minimal disruption. It usually failed. Usually made students push back harder.

Her pen trembled slightly before she forced herself to write again.

Coincidence, she told herself. Authority works sometimes.

Except she could feel the calm settle afterward, smooth and deliberate, like the room had been gently reset

rather than corrected.

After the bell, the class dissolved into the usual chaos—bags zipped, chairs scraped, conversations resumed mid-sentence. Allison lingered longer than necessary, reorganizing papers that didn't need reorganizing.

“Allison?”

She looked up.

Mr. Lang stood by his desk, already grading, his voice neutral and unremarkable.

“Yes?”

“Walk with me for a second?”

Her stomach tightened.

This was usually where things shifted. Where adults asked careful questions and pretended not to be evaluating the answers.

She nodded and followed him into the hallway.

The corridor was loud and crowded, lockers slamming, voices overlapping, announcements echoing faintly from somewhere overhead. The smell of disinfectant mixed with damp jackets and cafeteria food.

Mr. Lang walked beside her for several steps before speaking, timing his words between waves of noise.

“You’ve seemed... settled lately,” he said.

The word landed too close to the one Emily had used.

Allison kept her eyes forward. "Is that bad?"

He smiled faintly. "No. Just noticeable. A lot of students are running hot right now. College deadlines, finals, expectations." He shrugged. "You don't seem to be."

Allison searched for the trap and didn't find one.

"I guess I'm just trying to get through the year," she said.

"That's fair," he said easily. "Honestly? If everyone handled stress the way you do, my job would be much easier."

They reached the corner near the science wing. Mr. Lang slowed, then stopped.

"Well," he said, already turning back toward his classroom, "just wanted to check in. Keep doing what you're doing."

That was it.

No follow-up. No note taken. No suggestion to talk to anyone else.

The conversation ended as cleanly as it had started.

Allison stood there for a moment after he left, the hallway noise rushing back around her. Students brushed past without noticing her pause.

She felt... placed.

Not scrutinized. Not evaluated.

Allowed.

The rest of the day followed the same pattern.

In math class, a pop quiz was quietly postponed because the teacher decided the room “felt tense.” In the office, a line of students waiting for late passes dissolved when the secretary waved them through without comment. A security guard near the stairwell smiled and gestured instead of stopping people to check hall passes.

Nothing dramatic.

Just friction dissolving before it could bite.

By the final bell, Allison’s head ached—not from stress, but from the effort of staying alert. From bracing for resistance that never arrived.

Walking home, the school behind her felt oddly contained, like a system running more smoothly than it should.

At home, Emily was already at the kitchen table, homework spread out, pencil tapping softly. She glanced up.

“You okay?” Emily asked.

Allison nodded automatically. “Yeah.”

Emily watched her for a second longer than necessary, then returned to her work.

Allison went upstairs and closed her bedroom door, leaning back against it as she exhaled.

This was different.

The calm wasn't just easing moments anymore.

It was shaping them.

She pulled out her phone and opened the Notes app, fingers hovering.

She didn't write much.

Allison's Notes:

- Teachers don't push.
- Conversations end early.
- Systems smooth instead of resist.
- It feels like being... handled.

She stared at the last line, then added one more.

- I don't know who it's for.

She locked her phone and set it aside.

The quiet settled around her again, compliant and complete.

And for the first time, Allison wondered if the calm wasn't just something that happened near her—

But something that expected her to stay exactly where she was.

Interlude 4.5 — Unasked Questions — Interlude: Spring Semester

Mr. Lang had taught long enough to know when a class was about to unravel.

Spring semester was usually the worst of it. Seniors frayed at the edges, younger students restless, everyone half checked out and overcaffeinated. Tempers ran short. Drama bloomed in corners and spilled into the open with very little warning.

That was the pattern.

Which was why this class bothered him.

Third period should have been a mess by now. Not catastrophic — just noisy, distracted, prone to side conversations that turned sharp when he wasn't looking. The usual ecosystem of whispered arguments, lingering glances, phones angled just low enough to pretend they weren't being used.

Instead, it was... manageable.

Not perfect. Not silent. But smoother than it had any right to be.

Disagreements fizzled instead of escalating. Sarcasm landed and then went nowhere. Even the students who normally thrived on friction seemed to lose interest halfway through.

Mr. Lang caught himself thinking it was a relief.

He didn't question it at first. Good classes happened sometimes. Maybe the material had finally clicked. Maybe the seating chart change had done more than he'd expected.

Still.

He found himself intervening less. Clearing his throat instead of raising his voice. Letting moments resolve themselves.

And they did.

That was the strange part.

The class didn't feel disengaged. If anything, they felt contained. Like the energy that normally leaked out into conflict was staying put, redistributed into something quieter.

He glanced at his roster one afternoon, scanning names without a clear reason. Nothing jumped out. No obvious anchor student, no single personality holding the room together.

Though he did notice Allison more.

Not because she caused problems — she never had. But because she didn't.

She was steady in a way that made the rest of the room seem steadier by proximity. Present, but not demanding attention. Calm, without being flat.

Mr. Lang dismissed the thought almost immediately.

Correlation wasn't causation. He knew better than that.

And besides, teachers weren't supposed to speculate about students like that. You took the good days when they came. You didn't look for ghosts in the quiet.

Still, as he erased the board at the end of class and listened to the usual scrape of chairs and low chatter, he felt a flicker of unease he couldn't quite place.

The class emptied without incident.

No raised voices. No slammed doors. No lingering tension.

Just a room returning to neutral.

Mr. Lang capped the marker and told himself, firmly, that this was what normal was supposed to feel like.

Even if it didn't usually last.

Chapter 5 — The Path of Least Resistance

By Monday, Allison had learned something important.

The calm didn't like hesitation.

It wasn't obvious at first. It didn't announce itself or demand anything. It showed up in the smallest moments—those half-seconds where a choice hovered before settling.

Which hallway she took between classes.

Whether she spoke when she had something to say.

How long she let silence last before filling it.

Every time she paused—every time she weighed options instead of moving—the world seemed to resolve itself gently in the direction of least disruption.

At first, she told herself it was nothing.

Stress did strange things to perception. Senior year came with a constant background hum of pressure. Anyone would want things to feel smoother.

But imagination didn't usually come with patterns.

In chemistry, she noticed it again. She raised her hand halfway, then stopped, unsure whether her question would derail the explanation or expose that she'd missed something obvious. The teacher's gaze swept past her without slowing, landing on someone already leaning forward.

The question moved on.

The answer followed.

The class stayed on schedule.

Allison lowered her hand slowly, heart beating faster than it should have for something so small.

She felt relief first.

Then something colder underneath it.

In the hallway afterward, two students stepped into her path mid-argument. She slowed instinctively, bracing for the collision of voices and bodies.

They broke apart before she reached them.

An apology was murmured. Someone laughed it off. The space cleared.

Allison passed through untouched.

At lunch, Kara waved her over to their usual table. It was already loud—voices overlapping, energy buzzing sharp and bright. Someone was complaining about a weekend shift. Someone else was teasing too hard, the edge just beginning to show.

Allison slowed.

Just for a second.

She could already see how it would unfold. A joke would land wrong. Kara would escalate because she always did. Nothing catastrophic—but not smooth.

A chair scraped back at a quieter table nearby. Someone glanced up, smiled politely, and shifted their bag

without asking.

There was space.

Allison sat there instead.

The relief was immediate and undeniable.

Her shoulders loosened. Her breathing evened out. The noise of the cafeteria softened into something distant, manageable.

Across the room, Kara noticed. Their eyes met. Kara's brow furrowed in confusion before she shrugged and turned back to the conversation.

Allison told herself she'd explain later.

She didn't.

The calm didn't push her into decisions.

It just made some choices easier than others.

By the end of the day, Allison felt like she'd been quietly guided, nudged along paths that required less from her at every turn.

The unsettling part wasn't that the world felt easier.

It was that she felt herself leaning into it.

Walking home, she replayed the day—not the big moments, because there hadn't been any, but the dozens of small ones. The times she'd almost spoken. The opinions she'd kept to herself. The disagreements she'd let dissolve before they reached her.

The streetlights flickered on early, casting soft pools of yellow along the sidewalk. Cars slowed when she reached intersections. A conversation ahead of her dropped in volume before she passed.

Nothing dramatic.

Nothing forced.

Just... cooperative.

At home, Emily was on the couch, a textbook open in her lap, the TV murmuring low enough to be background noise. She looked up as Allison came in.

“You bail on Kara today?” Emily asked.

Allison hesitated, caught by how easily the truth could slide in either direction.

“Just sat somewhere else,” she said.

Emily watched her for a moment, longer than necessary. “You’ve been doing that a lot.”

“Doing what?”

“Choosing the quiet option.”

The words settled into Allison’s chest with uncomfortable precision.

She dropped her backpack by the stairs and sat on the arm of the chair instead of the couch, keeping space between them. “Is that bad?”

Emily flipped a page, then another, buying time.

“No,” she said finally. “Just... noticeable.”

That word again.

Noticeable.

Allison nodded, even though Emily had already looked back down.

Later, alone in her room, Allison opened her Notes app without thinking.

The blank screen felt expectant now, less like a record and more like a mirror.

Allison's Notes:

- It's easier not to interrupt.
- Easier not to disagree.
- Easier not to stand out.
- Easier to let things pass.

She stared at the list, thumb hovering.

- Easier to disappear.

Her chest tightened.

She deleted the line immediately.

That wasn't true.

She was still here. Still thinking. Still choosing.

Wasn't she?

She set the phone aside and lay back on her bed, staring at the slow rotation of the ceiling fan. Each turn was identical to the last, steady and unremarkable.

The calm settled around her again, patient and accommodating.

And Allison understood something that made her stomach twist:

The world didn't need her to change.

It didn't need her to grow, or push, or take up space.

It just needed her to stay easy.

And the longer she let it happen, the more she could feel the difference blurring—

Between what she wanted...

And what required the least resistance.

Chapter 6 — Consent-First Contact

The stall door clicked softly when Allison locked it. She stayed there longer than necessary, listening to the low, even hum of the ventilation fan until her breathing matched it. The quiet helped, but only in the way a closed door helped—temporary, borrowed.

She balanced her phone against her knee and opened the notes app without thinking about it. The familiar blank screen felt like an invitation and a demand at the same time. It waited for her in a way people rarely did—patient, but expectant.

She typed with one thumb.

- She asked first.

- She didn't explain anything.

- I don't know if that makes me feel safer or worse.

The first line came easily. The second took longer. By the time she reached the third, her thumb hovered, suspended, as if finishing the thought would make it real in a way she couldn't undo.

She thought about deleting it. About rewriting it into something more neutral. Something that sounded less like a feeling and more like an observation.

She didn't.

She typed it anyway.

Then she stared at the screen, waiting for the feeling that usually followed—relief, containment, the sense that she'd put something somewhere it could stay. It didn't come. The words just sat there, inert and heavy, like they were waiting for her to do something else with them.

She locked her phone without rereading any of it.

The bell rang while she was washing her hands. The sound cut through her thoughts sharply, loud in the small space. She flinched, then felt faintly ridiculous for it. She looked up at her reflection, half-expecting to see something different in her face—something that would justify the tightness in her chest.

There wasn't. She still looked like herself.

That somehow made it worse.

She dried her hands slowly. Checked the mirror again, as if time might change the answer. Then she took an extra second before opening the door.

The hallway rushed in around her—voices overlapping, lockers slamming, the familiar current of people moving because they were supposed to. Everything looked exactly the same. That should have been reassuring.

Instead, it made her feel slightly out of step, like she'd paused while everything else kept going and now had to decide how to reenter the flow.

Her phone buzzed almost immediately.

Where'd you disappear to? — Kara

Allison read the message twice. She could hear Kara's voice in it—casual, curious, already half-amused.

Allison typed, erased, then typed again.

Needed air.

It was true. It also avoided everything else. She sent it before she could second-guess herself and slipped the phone into her pocket, as if not looking at it might keep the moment contained.

Outside, the courtyard felt cooler than the hallway, the late-afternoon light stretching shadows across the stone edging and benches. Allison chose a seat that put her half in the sun, half out of it, and focused on ordinary details—the scrape of shoes on concrete, the distant sound of someone laughing too loudly, the faint smell of cut grass.

She told herself she was just taking a minute.

The idea didn't hold.

Time didn't feel like it was passing normally. It stretched, thinned, gathered itself strangely around her.

That was when she noticed Mara.

Evan's mom stood a few steps away, not moving closer, not pretending to be busy. Allison had been in her kitchen more times than she could count. Had eaten her food, listened to her talk about grocery sales and weather and whether Evan was sleeping enough. Mara was familiar in the way adults became familiar when

they were part of someone else's safe place.

Which made it strange that she hadn't just sat down.

Mara waited until Allison looked up.

"Allison," she said gently. "May I sit?"

The question landed softly.

And didn't go away.

Allison almost nodded out of habit. The motion started in her neck before she stopped it, surprised by her own hesitation. The pause stretched—not long enough to be awkward, but long enough for her to feel it in her shoulders, her jaw, the way her hands had curled unconsciously against her thighs.

She realized, distantly, that she was holding herself very still.

"Yes," she said finally.

The word felt heavier than it should have been.

Mara chose a place beside her that left room between them—not the easy closeness of a kitchen table, but not distance either. Enough space that Allison was aware of it. Enough space that it felt intentional.

"I'm not here to explain anything," Mara said. "And I don't have answers unless you ask for them."

Allison folded her hands in her lap. Her fingers pressed together too tightly before she noticed and forced them to relax. She nodded once, because nodding was easier

than speaking.

“Oh,” she said.

The sound surprised her with how small it was.

Mara smiled, careful and warm without being reassuring. “I just wanted to check in. And to tell you that if you ever want to talk—about anything—you can choose to.”

Choose.

The word settled low and heavy, behind Allison’s sternum. It didn’t echo. It sank.

Mara didn’t soften it. She didn’t follow it with a suggestion, or a next step, or the kind of gentle guidance Allison was used to from adults who thought they were helping. There was no *when*, no *how*, no framing that made the choice easier.

The absence felt deliberate.

Allison had spent years navigating expectations she could sense without being told—teachers who wanted compliance, counselors who wanted answers, strangers who mistook calm for capability. This was different. This wasn’t something she could smooth over by being agreeable.

This was space.

And space demanded something just by existing.

She became aware of Evan then, standing near the edge of the courtyard. He leaned against a tree, hands in his

pockets, watching without staring. He didn't step in. Didn't look away. He held himself exactly where he was, like staying there required effort.

Allison wondered how much effort that took.

When Mara stood, she didn't stretch the moment or cut it short. She inclined her head slightly, as if acknowledging that the exchange had been complete on its own terms.

"Nothing is required," she said. "Including a response."

Then she walked away.

The space she left behind felt larger, not emptier—like something had been carefully removed rather than added.

Allison stayed where she was, watching students cross the courtyard, listening to conversations drift past her without catching. Her phone buzzed again in her pocket. She didn't check it. The idea of answering anyone felt heavier than it should have.

For the first time since the watching had begun, she didn't feel managed.

She felt trusted.

The realization didn't bring relief. It brought weight. Trust meant attention. It meant that doing nothing was no longer invisible—it was something someone else would notice, something someone else would have to account for.

Evan joined her only after a full minute had passed, sitting far enough away that their shoulders didn't touch. He adjusted his position once, like he'd chosen the spot carefully and was still checking that it was right.

"You okay?" he asked.

"I think so," Allison said. The words came out slower than usual, as if she were testing each one before letting it go. "I just... didn't expect that."

Evan nodded, looking out across the courtyard instead of at her. "Yeah."

They sat in silence for a moment longer. It wasn't awkward, exactly. It just wasn't empty.

"She didn't tell me anything," Allison said after a bit. "Which I know was the point. But it feels strange to have someone show up just to... not do that."

Evan's mouth curved slightly. Not quite a smile. "That sounds like her."

"Does it?"

"Yeah," he said. "She's big on not deciding things for people. Even when it would be easier."

"Easier for who?"

"For everyone," Evan said. "Including her."

Allison picked at a loose thread on her sleeve. "It feels like I'm supposed to decide something," she said. "But I don't know what the decision even is."

Evan nodded again. "You don't have to decide anything right now."

"That still feels like a decision."

"Yeah," he admitted. "It kind of is."

"I'm used to people telling me what the next step is," Allison said quietly. "Or at least acting like there is one."

"My mom thinks people do better when they get to notice what they want before being pushed," Evan said.

"What if you don't know what you want?"

"Then you don't know yet," he said. "That's still information."

She let that sit between them.

"I don't like how much I'm thinking about it," Allison said. "Like I can't stop replaying it."

"You don't have to talk about it with me," Evan said.

"I know. I just don't want to pretend it didn't happen."

"I don't think you are."

"How can you tell?"

"Because you're here," he said. "And because you didn't make a joke about it."

She huffed a quiet laugh. "I do that."

"Yeah," Evan said, smiling now. "You do."

“Are you okay?” she asked him. “I mean—this has to be weird for you too.”

“It’s not nothing,” Evan said. “But I trust her. And I trust you.”

The word landed harder than she expected.

“You don’t even know what’s going on.”

“Neither do you,” he said. “That seems fair.”

They sat there another moment.

“You don’t have to do anything,” Evan said again.

“And if you want space, that’s okay too.”

“I don’t want space,” Allison said quickly. Then paused. “I just don’t know what I want instead.”

“That makes sense,” Evan said.

She believed him.

That didn’t make the pressure in her chest ease. It only clarified that whatever this was, it wasn’t going to resolve on its own—and that, somehow, she was now responsible for how it didn’t.

Chapter 7 — The Invitation

Allison read Evan's text three times before setting her phone down.

You want to go for a walk later?

It was simple. Casual. The kind of message that usually came with an immediate answer, or at least a joke that bought her time. She stared at the screen until the words stopped feeling like language and started feeling like a decision she hadn't agreed to make yet.

She didn't not want to go.

That was the problem.

She rolled onto her side, phone pressed loosely against her palm, and tried to imagine herself already outside — jacket on, walking beside him, conversation unfolding the way it always had. The image didn't feel wrong. It just felt heavier than it used to, like stepping into a room where the air pressure had changed slightly and she hadn't adjusted yet.

She opened the notes app out of reflex, then closed it again. Whatever this was, it didn't belong there. It wasn't something she could break down into lines and leave behind.

She typed a response. Deleted it. Tried again. Deleted that too.

The cursor blinked patiently, waiting for her to decide whether this counted as something she was allowed to

hesitate over.

Minutes passed.

She set the phone face down on the bed, then flipped it back over a moment later, as if it might have changed its mind in the meantime. It hadn't. Evan hadn't followed up. He wasn't pushing.

That made the silence heavier instead of lighter.

Her mom knocked softly on the open bedroom door. "Dinner in about ten," she said. Then she hesitated, just long enough to make the question careful. "You okay?"

Allison stared at the wall. "Yeah. Just thinking."

Her mom leaned against the doorframe but didn't come in. "Thinking about school stuff, or thinking-thinking?"

The distinction mattered more than Allison wanted it to.

"I don't know," Allison said finally.

Her mom nodded, accepting the answer for what it was. "That happens."

They stood there for a moment, neither of them moving. Allison became aware of how much space her mom was giving her — not crowding, not retreating. Waiting.

"I might go for a walk," Allison said, the words surprising her as they left her mouth.

"With Evan?" her mom asked gently.

"Yeah."

Her mom smiled a little. “That sounds nice.”

It didn’t sound like permission. It didn’t sound like expectation. Just acknowledgment.

After her mom left, Allison picked up her phone again. She thought about the way she’d been asked earlier. About how no one had told her what the right response was supposed to be. About how choosing nothing had still felt like choosing.

Her thumb hovered.

Yeah. I think so.

She sent it before she could talk herself out of it.

The reply came a few minutes later.

Cool. I’ll come by.

Her stomach flipped — not unpleasantly, but sharply. She set the phone down and breathed through it, counting slowly until the feeling settled into something manageable.

A short while later, she heard a knock downstairs.

“Evan’s here,” her mom called from the kitchen.

The normalcy of it helped. Just a little.

Allison grabbed her jacket and headed down the hall. Evan stood near the door when she reached the entryway, hands in his pockets, posture careful like he wasn’t sure how much space to take up. He smiled when he saw her — not too wide, not asking for

anything.

“Hey,” he said.

“Hey.”

They stepped outside together, the door closing softly behind them.

The evening air was cooler than Allison expected, the sky hovering between day and night. They walked without talking at first, turning down the familiar side street without discussing it. Their steps didn’t line up perfectly, but Evan adjusted after a few seconds without comment.

They walked in silence again, their steps uneven but close enough that Allison could feel Evan’s presence beside her without looking.

She became aware of the space between their hands.

Not in a deliberate way. Just a quiet noticing — the distance, the way it shifted as they walked, how easily it could close if either of them moved half an inch closer. The thought wasn’t fully formed. It didn’t arrive as a want so much as a pull, a sense that something simple might make the heaviness ease.

Her fingers flexed once at her side.

Evan’s hand moved at the same moment.

It wasn’t sudden. Just a small adjustment, his arm angling slightly toward her, his hand opening as if by reflex. For a fraction of a second, Allison was sure he

was going to reach for her.

Then he stopped.

His hand hovered, then drifted back to his side, fingers curling loosely instead. He didn't look at her. He didn't apologize or explain. The movement was quiet enough that it could have been coincidence.

But the space between them felt different afterward — charged, not closed.

Allison let her hand fall still again. She didn't know what it would have meant if he'd touched her. She only knew that the absence of it lingered longer than she expected.

They kept walking.

"I wasn't sure you'd want to," Evan said eventually.

"I wasn't sure either," Allison admitted.

That earned a small smile. "Fair."

They walked in silence again. Not empty — just waiting.

"I keep thinking I should say something," Allison said after a while. "And then I don't know where to start."

"You don't have to," Evan said.

"I know." She hesitated. "But I don't want to pretend everything's the same."

He nodded. "Yeah."

The agreement felt heavier than reassurance would have.

“Things feel different,” she said. “Not bad. Just... like they don’t slide past me the way they used to.”

Evan thought about that. “Like you’re noticing them more?”

“Maybe,” she said. “Or like they’re noticing me.”

He didn’t answer right away.

“That makes sense,” he said finally. “Even if it’s uncomfortable.”

They reached the end of the block and turned back, the walk looping instead of progressing. Allison realized she didn’t mind. The motion helped, even if nothing was resolving.

“I’m worried that if I don’t talk about it, it’ll turn into something else,” she said. “Like it’ll keep growing just because I’m avoiding it.”

“And if you talk about it before you’re ready,” Evan said, “it might turn into something you didn’t mean.”

She looked at him. “You’re really okay with me not knowing yet?”

He shrugged. “I don’t think knowing fast is the same as knowing right.”

That sat with her.

When they stopped in front of her house again, neither of them moved right away.

“Thanks for coming,” Evan said.

“Thanks for asking,” she replied.

“You don’t have to figure this out tonight,” he added.

“I know,” Allison said. And meant it.

But when she went back inside, the quiet felt altered — not hostile, not safe. Just no longer neutral.

Chapter 8 — Arrival

Allison went home after the walk.

Dinner was already on the table when she came in—plates warm, steam rising, her mom moving between the stove and the counter with the easy efficiency of routine. Emily was at a friend's house, and her dad wouldn't be home until later, which made the table feel larger than it needed to.

"How was the walk?" her mom asked.

"Nice," Allison said. The word slid into place easily, like it always had.

She sat. She ate. She answered questions that didn't require much of her. The clink of forks and the low murmur of conversation filled the room, familiar and grounding in a way that suddenly felt too close, like the walls had shifted inward by a fraction she couldn't measure.

Nothing was wrong.

That was the problem.

She noticed it in the small things first—the way she chewed without tasting, the way her foot kept tapping against the chair rung even after she told it to stop. She waited for the normal rhythm of the evening to settle her, the way it always had.

It didn't.

After dinner, she helped clear the table without being asked. She rinsed plates, stacked them in the dishwasher, wiped down the counter even though it was already clean. Her mom thanked her without looking up, already turning the page of her book as the evening folded into its usual shape.

Allison waited for that shape to hold her.

It didn't.

She drifted down the hall, paused in her doorway, then sat on the edge of her bed. The quiet pressed in—not heavy exactly, just insufficient. She stared at the faint scuff near the baseboard she'd never bothered to notice before, tracing its outline with her eyes until it lost meaning.

Evan's house came to mind without invitation.

Not as a plan. Not even as a want. Just as a place that existed slightly outside the shape of the evening, where the air might feel different even if nothing else was.

The thought unsettled her.

She picked up her phone, turned it over in her hands, set it back down. Then she picked it up again and typed before she could argue herself out of it.

Are you home?

The reply came a few minutes later.

Yeah.

Nothing else.

The simplicity of it landed heavier than reassurance would have.

“I’m going out for a bit,” Allison called toward the living room.

Her mom looked up from her book. “Okay. Text me when you get there.”

“Yeah.”

The door closed softly behind her.

The walk felt different this time. Not hesitant. Deliberate. Each step carried its own weight, the streetlights flicking on one by one as she passed beneath them. The familiar route felt narrower, like she was walking inside a decision instead of toward one.

When Evan opened the door, she realized how tightly she’d been holding herself.

“Hey,” he said.

“Hey.”

He stepped aside without comment. She crossed the threshold before she could think about it too much.

The door closed behind her.

Allison didn’t realize how tense she’d been until that moment.

The sound was ordinary—the soft click of the latch settling—but it landed like punctuation.

Evan's house smelled the same as it always had: warm, faintly sweet, familiar enough that the difference was in how she felt, not where she was.

Mara was at the kitchen table with a stack of mail spread in front of her. Evan's dad sat nearby, reading glasses on, a mug cooling beside him as he scrolled through something on his phone.

"Hey, Allison," Mara said, looking up with an easy smile. "I'm glad you stopped by."

"Hi," Allison said.

Evan's dad glanced up. "Hey there." He nodded once and went back to what he'd been doing, the interaction complete.

No spotlight. No expectation.

Allison set her jacket over the back of a chair instead of hanging it up. The small choice felt important, though she couldn't have said why.

They moved into the living room. The furniture was exactly where it had always been. Allison noticed it anyway—the couch angled toward the window, the shallow dip in the cushion, the low table marked with years of use.

She perched on the edge of the couch. Evan sat beside her, close but careful.

Mara brought her mug in and settled into the armchair across from them. Evan's dad followed a moment later, easing into his usual spot, already half-absorbed again.

He was present without being involved, the way adults sometimes were when they trusted a room to hold itself.

The television stayed off.

“This feels different,” Allison said before she could stop herself.

Evan glanced at her. “Yeah.”

No follow-up. No correction.

“I thought coming here would make it easier,” she said. “Like things would snap back into place.”

Mara watched her quietly. Evan waited.

“They don’t,” Allison said. The words felt steadier once they were out. “It doesn’t.”

Evan nodded. “I kind of figured.”

That surprised her. “Why?”

“Because you’re sitting like you’re waiting for something to go wrong,” he said. Not unkindly. Just observant.

She shifted, realizing he was right. Let her shoulders drop a fraction. It helped. A little.

“I don’t know what I’m supposed to do,” she said. “I feel like if I move the wrong way, I’ll break something. But I don’t know what that something is.”

Mara didn’t rush to answer.

“That sounds exhausting,” she said finally.

Evan's dad adjusted his glasses. "Sometimes noticing things comes before knowing what to do about them," he said, still not quite looking at Allison. "That part can feel worse."

The comment wasn't framed as advice. It didn't demand agreement.

Allison let out a breath she hadn't realized she was holding.

"I don't want to mess anything up," she said.

"You're not," Evan said. Then, after a pause, "And even if things change, that doesn't mean they're broken."

She looked at him. "You don't know that."

"No," he agreed. "But I know pretending nothing's changing won't help."

Mara smoothed the edge of the cushion with one hand. She stayed where she was. She didn't fill the silence that followed.

The room didn't open up.

If anything, it felt more deliberate—like it was holding still to see what Allison would do next.

Allison leaned back against the couch, testing the sensation. It didn't swallow her the way safety used to. It supported her without insisting.

The conversation didn't end so much as loosen.

It drifted into quieter shapes—Evan’s dad commenting on something he’d read earlier, Mara mentioning a neighbor’s new dog, the kind of ordinary talk that didn’t require anything from Allison beyond listening. She stayed curled slightly forward at first, hands still folded tight in her lap, but she noticed that she wasn’t holding her breath anymore.

Her shoulders lowered without her telling them to.

She leaned back another inch against the couch.

No one remarked on it.

Evan shifted beside her at some point, stretching his legs out, the movement casual enough that it didn’t feel like a decision. Their knees brushed lightly this time, and neither of them moved away. The contact stayed—unacknowledged, unclaimed—until it stopped feeling like something she needed to track.

She let herself sink a little deeper into the cushion.

Mara stood to refill her mug and offered Allison more tea with a tilt of the pot, waiting for a nod instead of assuming. Allison accepted, wrapping her hands around the warmth again, noticing that it didn’t make her flinch this time.

Time passed.

She wasn’t sure how much.

The clock on the wall ticked softly, steady and unconcerned. Evan’s dad eventually excused himself to check something in the garage, his absence barely

registering except for the way the room shifted slightly around it.

Allison realized she felt normal.

Not fixed. Not resolved.

Just not braced.

She sat with that for a few more minutes, letting it settle the way dinner hadn't.

Eventually, the thought of home returned—not as pressure, not as retreat, but as the next step in a sequence she could handle.

“I should probably head back,” Allison said.

The words didn't feel heavy when she said them.

Evan nodded immediately. “Okay.”

No hesitation. No disappointment.

Mara smiled. “I'm glad you came by.”

So was Allison.

She stood, slipping her jacket back on, the movement unhurried. Evan walked her to the door, stopping where he always did, giving her space to go or pause.

“Thanks,” she said. She meant it for all of them.

“Anytime,” Evan said—not as a promise, not as an invitation. Just a fact.

The door closed behind her with the same soft click as before.

This time, it didn't feel like punctuation.

It felt like a comma.

Chapter 9 — Observation Without Judgment

Allison woke up tired in a way sleep hadn't touched.

Not exhausted. Just... flat. Like something had been running quietly in the background all night and hadn't shut off when she did.

She lay still for a while, staring at the ceiling, cataloging familiar details—the faint crack near the corner, the way the light shifted when a car passed outside—until the room felt solid again.

It helped.

A little.

The house woke around her. Cabinets opening downstairs. Emily's door creaking. Her dad moving through the kitchen with the unhurried sounds of a morning that expected her to join it.

Allison stayed where she was.

The clock ticked forward without comment. She watched the numbers change, aware she wasn't late yet—just lingering in the narrow space before obligation made itself unavoidable.

Eventually, she sat up.

The movement felt heavier than it should have. She waited for readiness to arrive.

It didn't.

She got dressed anyway. Moved through the routine on momentum rather than intention. Brushed her teeth. Pulled her hair back. The mirror reflected someone who looked fine enough to pass.

Downstairs, breakfast was already underway. Emily scrolled through her phone over a bowl of cereal. Her dad stood at the counter with a mug, glancing up as Allison poured herself coffee instead of eating.

“Morning,” he said.

“Morning.”

No one asked more than that. No one noticed she felt slightly out of sync.

That almost helped.

By the time she grabbed her bag and stepped outside, the day had already decided she was part of it.

School arrived anyway.

The hallway noise hit her all at once—voices overlapping, lockers slamming, someone laughing too loudly down the corridor. Allison adjusted her pace until it matched the flow around her, neither rushing nor lingering.

Remaining unremarkable used to be automatic.

Now it took effort.

Kara found her near their lockers, already talking about a quiz she hadn’t studied for. Allison listened, nodded, laughed at the right moments. The delay between sound

and response was small, but she felt every fraction of it.

“You okay?” Kara asked eventually.

“Yeah. Just tired.”

Kara’s eyes narrowed slightly. “You’ve been saying that a lot.”

Allison shrugged. “It’s been a week.”

“That it has,” Kara said, unconvinced.

The bell rang, scattering them toward their first classes.

First period passed quietly. Allison took notes she didn’t need, copying down phrases she already understood just to keep her hands moving. The teacher paused near her desk once, then moved on without comment.

The absence registered.

Second period was louder. Group discussion. Chairs scraping. Allison spoke when called on, her answers correct and brief. She could feel eyes on her afterward—not judgmental, just... attentive.

She stopped trying to interpret it.

By midmorning, she was tracking patterns.

Who looked at her and then away.

Who didn’t look at her at all.

Which teachers paused an extra beat before moving on.

No one said anything.

That was the unsettling part.

Between classes, she slowed her pace, letting clusters of students pass her. The halls felt narrower than they should have. She told herself it was nothing.

By third period, the effort of staying neutral had settled into her shoulders.

Lunch came as a relief she hadn't expected.

Kara slid into the seat across from her, launching into a story about someone else's drama. Allison listened, grateful for the familiar rhythm of Kara filling space. She contributed when she could, but each response felt measured, like she was choosing from a smaller set of safe options.

Halfway through lunch, Kara stopped talking.

"You're being weird," she said. Not unkindly. "Not bad-weird. Just... distant."

Allison blinked. "I'm not trying to be."

"I know," Kara said. "That's kind of why it's weird."

The cafeteria noise filled the gap.

"I just don't know what to say yet," Allison admitted.

Kara leaned back, studying her. "About... something specific?"

Allison shook her head. "I don't even know what it is."

That earned her a longer look.

“Okay,” Kara said finally. “Just don’t shut me out, yeah?”

“I won’t.”

She meant it.

The promise still felt heavier than it should have.

The afternoon dragged. Bells. Seats. Teachers’ voices blurring together. Allison noticed how often she checked her surroundings, how carefully she chose where to sit, how much effort it took not to scan faces for reactions.

By the final bell, she felt wrung out.

Walking home, she replayed the previous night without meaning to—the way Evan’s living room had stayed steady, the way she hadn’t needed to brace the whole time.

What she’d felt at Evan’s house didn’t follow her.

At home, the quiet felt thin again. Manageable. But thin.

She went to her room and opened her notes app, fingers hovering over the screen. She didn’t write anything at first. Just stared at the blank page, aware of how much she wanted to record what she was noticing—and how risky it felt to make it concrete.

Eventually, she typed a single line.

- Being watched isn’t the same as being judged.

She read it once. Then again.

Then she locked her phone and set it aside, the thought unresolved—but held, for now.

Interlude 9.5 — Signals — Signals

Mr. Harlan noticed the quiet first.

Not the absence of noise — his classroom was rarely loud — but the way sound seemed to settle differently than it used to. Students spoke when called on. Laughed at the right moments. Shifted in their seats like they always had.

And yet.

The usual undercurrent of small disruptions — whispered comments, restless movement, the subtle testing of boundaries — had thinned. Not vanished. Just softened, as if everyone had agreed, without discussing it, to be more careful.

That wasn't necessarily a problem.

It was just something to note.

He adjusted the stack of papers on his desk and continued the lesson. Classrooms went through moods. Weeks blurred into one another. Sometimes a stretch of calm was just that — calm.

Still, he found himself paying attention to the room as a whole. Not to any one student, but to the spaces between them. The places where energy usually leaked and now didn't.

No one was disengaged.

No one was withdrawn.

If anything, they seemed attentive in a way that felt slightly rehearsed.

That gave him pause.

At the end of the period, the students filed out in an orderly stream. Mr. Harlan erased the board at his usual pace, making a mental note he wasn't sure he'd need later.

He'd learned to trust notes more than instincts.

In the faculty lounge, the coffee machine hissed and sputtered while someone argued with the printer. Mr. Harlan poured himself a cup and took a seat near the window, grading essays he'd already skimmed once.

"Have you noticed the classes lately?" Ms. Chen asked, setting her mug down nearby.

He looked up. "In what way?"

She considered her words. "They're... smoother. Not better. Just smoother."

"That happens," he said. "Especially this time of year."

"I know," she said quickly. "I don't think it's anything. It just stood out."

He nodded. "I've noticed it too. But I'd call it background noise for now."

"That makes sense," she said, visibly relieved.

"Probably just stress settling differently."

"Probably," he agreed.

They sat in companionable silence for a moment.

“Still,” Ms. Chen added, almost as an afterthought, “if it keeps up, I might mention it in a few weeks.”

“Fair,” he said. “No harm in paying attention.”

The bell rang.

Back in his classroom later, Mr. Harlan straightened chairs that didn’t need it, more out of habit than concern. The room looked exactly the way it always had.

He took that as a good sign.

For now.

Chapter 10 — Political Undercurrent

Allison didn't know the conversations were happening.

That was part of what made them possible.

Her days continued in their careful, quiet pattern.
School. Home. The small adjustments she'd started
making without realizing she was making them.
Nothing pressed in hard enough to demand attention.

Nothing broke.

Elsewhere, the pauses were noticed.

The woman who watched from the library window
marked Allison's arrival time without writing it down.
The hall monitor who waved her through did so more
deliberately the second time. A counselor glanced at a
schedule and chose not to adjust it.

Each decision was small. Reasonable. Defensible.

Taken together, they formed a net that didn't touch her.

"We're still not intervening," someone said quietly.

"No," another agreed. "There's no need."

A pause followed—not hesitation, but consideration.

"She's stable," a third voice said. "More than we
expected."

No one corrected the phrasing.

The room they were in wasn't formal. A table. Chairs
that didn't match. Coffee gone cold in mismatched

mugs. This wasn't a council or a tribunal. It was a place where people who knew each other well enough to disagree without posturing spoke carefully.

"Stability isn't the same as safety," someone said.

"No," the first voice replied. "But it's not nothing."

Another pause. This one lasted longer.

"She's absorbing it," someone else said. "The ambient pressure. It's... smoothing out."

That earned a look.

"We need to be careful with that word," someone said.

"I know," came the answer. "I'm not saying it's ideal. I'm saying it's effective."

Silence settled around that.

Not approval.

Not rejection.

Assessment.

"She hasn't pushed back," the first voice continued.

"She's adjusting."

"And no one's had to redirect her," someone added.

"No containment. No correction."

"That's the concern," a quieter voice said.

But even that wasn't framed as alarm.

Just... data.

The conversation moved on, the way careful conversations did—sideways, into adjacent topics that weren't really separate. Schedules. Coverage. Who would notice if something changed, and who wouldn't.

"She's in school every day," someone said. "She's responsive. Cooperative."

The word sat there longer than the others had.

No one said it was a problem.

No one said it wasn't.

"Let's not disturb the equilibrium," the first voice said finally. "Not yet."

Heads nodded—not in agreement, exactly. In alignment.

Not because they all wanted the same thing.

Because this outcome cost them the least.

Allison felt the effects before she felt the reason.

A teacher deferred to her without realizing it. A class discussion shifted away from a topic just as she started to feel uncomfortable. A deadline was extended without explanation.

Each moment felt like kindness.

Together, they felt like constraint.

She couldn't have named it if asked. She only knew that the space around her felt... curated. Like the edges had been sanded down just enough to keep her from catching on them.

At lunch, Kara complained about a substitute who'd been strict about phones.

"They didn't say anything to you, though," Kara said, frowning slightly. "Weird."

Allison shrugged. "Maybe they didn't notice."

Kara didn't look convinced.

After school, Evan walked with her part of the way home. He didn't mention the changes. Neither did she. The quiet between them felt shared, but not empty.

"You still okay?" he asked at the corner where they usually split up.

"I think so," Allison said.

The phrase had stopped meaning reassurance. It had become a placeholder.

Evan nodded, accepting it for what it was.

That night, Allison opened her notes app and stared at the screen without typing.

She didn't know what question to ask.

That bothered her more than not having answers.

She set the phone down and lay back, staring at the ceiling while the house settled around her. The safety of

it felt intact. Nothing threatened her. Nothing demanded anything of her.

And still—

She felt herself being held in place.

Somewhere else, someone looked at a pattern and decided it was acceptable.

Not good.

Not just.

Acceptable.

And that was enough.

Chapter 11 — Reasonable Refusal

Allison knew it was coming this time.

The feeling arrived before the words did — the slight tightening in her chest, the way her awareness sharpened around the edges like she was stepping onto a narrow path. She recognized it now, the shape of the moment where someone was about to make things easier for her.

She didn't want easier. She wanted normal.

In math, the desks were already arranged for group work when she walked in. Names were written on the board in tidy clusters, each circled in a different color. Allison scanned the list automatically, finding Kara's name first, then her own. It was circled too — but set apart, connected to a group she didn't usually work with. Smaller. Quieter.

The teacher noticed her looking. "Oh," she said lightly, as if remembering something mid-thought. "Allison, if you'd rather work independently today, that's fine too."

The words were gentle. Optional. Reasonable.

Allison felt her shoulders tense.

She took a breath — just one, enough to keep her voice steady. "I'm okay with the group," she said. "I'd like to do it the regular way."

The teacher smiled immediately. "Of course. I just wanted to give you options."

“I know,” Allison said. She hesitated, then added carefully, “I don’t need the option today.”

“That’s great,” the teacher said warmly. “I love seeing students advocate for themselves.”

Advocate.

The word sat oddly in her head as Allison walked to her desk. It felt larger than what she’d done. Louder. As if refusing an accommodation required a kind of performance she hadn’t agreed to give.

The group work began. At first, it felt normal — numbers on paper, the familiar scratch of pencils, someone sighing too loudly when they got stuck. Allison explained her reasoning once, twice. The others nodded. They moved on.

But every few minutes, the teacher drifted back to their table.

“You’re doing fine,” she said once, pausing behind Allison’s chair.

“I know,” Allison replied, too quickly.

“Just making sure,” the teacher said, smiling.

By the end of the period, Allison felt like she’d spent the hour holding something upright that wanted to tip.

In science later, the desks had been rearranged again.

“Allison,” the teacher said as students filtered in, “why don’t you work with Jenna today?”

Jenna glanced up, surprised.

Allison paused. She'd worked with her lab partner for weeks. They had a rhythm.

"Can I stay where I am?" Allison asked.

The teacher blinked. "Oh — sure. I just thought—"

"I'd rather not switch," Allison said, keeping her voice even. "We're in the middle of something."

The teacher nodded. "Of course. That's fine."

He moved on.

The work took longer anyway. The teacher hovered. Instructions were repeated. Allison's data was double-checked in a way it hadn't been before.

Her choice stuck — technically.

But it didn't land.

By lunchtime, Allison felt like she'd been arguing with air all day.

She carried her tray to the table she and Kara usually claimed, sliding into the seat with more care than necessary. Kara was already there, tapping her fork against the edge of her plate in a restless rhythm.

"You look like you've been arguing with air," Kara said.

Allison huffed softly. "It feels like that."

"Still?"

“Worse.”

Before Kara could press, a tray landed at the end of the table.

“Mind if I sit?”

Evan’s voice was casual, but his eyes flicked between them, already reading the temperature of the conversation.

“Go ahead,” Kara said. “We’re mid-crisis, apparently.”

Evan smiled faintly. “Those are my favorite kinds.”

Allison managed a small smile that didn’t quite stick.

“What’s going on?” Evan asked.

Allison hesitated. “Teachers keep adjusting things. Without asking.”

“She got skipped for a presentation,” Kara said.
“Completely.”

Evan’s eyebrows lifted. “Skipped?”

Allison nodded. “And then they keep offering outs. Extensions. Switching partners.”

“That doesn’t sound terrible,” Evan said slowly.

“It’s not,” Allison said. “That’s the problem.”

Evan leaned back. “Okay. Then why does it feel bad?”

“Because I didn’t ask for it,” Allison said. “And when I say I don’t need it, it still stays.”

“That’s not how no works,” Kara said.

Evan went quiet. “If someone offers flexibility and you decline it, the decline should matter.”

Allison looked at him. “That’s what I thought.”

Kara crossed her arms. “It feels like they’ve already decided she needs help.”

“I don’t,” Allison said quickly.

“I know,” Kara said.

Evan’s voice was softer. “They’re acting like they’re preventing something.”

“That’s worse,” Allison said.

They sat with that until the bell rang.

After lunch, it happened again in English. Then again, quieter, later in the day. Each time Allison said no, it was acknowledged — praised, even — and then carefully absorbed.

By the final bell, she felt scraped thin.

She didn’t go home.

The turn toward the creek came without decision. The path was familiar under her shoes, the air cooler as the trees closed in. The sound of the water reached her first.

She sat on the rock she always used and watched the creek move.

Usually, this helped.

Today, it didn't fix anything.

"I said no," she murmured.

The creek flowed on.

The anger stayed. Not sharp. Not explosive. Alive.

When she finally stood, she felt steadier carrying it.

At home, she went straight to the kitchen and opened her notes app.

- Saying no only works if someone listens.
- Being given options isn't the same as being asked.
- I think they're being careful with me.
- I think that means they've already decided something.
- I don't want to disappear politely.

She locked her phone.

She had been calm. Polite. Clear.

And it hadn't mattered.

That was the part she couldn't stop thinking about.

Chapter 25 — Return to Ordinary Life

*Allison's Notes (checklist titled: "Normal"):

- English essay
- College email (open, don't reply)
- Text Kara back

Kara shoved the packet of graduation forms into Allison's hands like it was a rescue line. The paper bent slightly under the force, corners curling where Kara's fingers had already worried them.

"If we don't do these now, we die," Kara said, already half-turned, already moving toward her locker. "I'm not kidding. I will simply pass away in the hallway."

Allison looked down at the forms. Names. Dates. Signatures. Lines that assumed the future was something you could schedule if you just filled in the blanks correctly.

The paper smelled faintly of toner and dust. It was warm from Kara's hands.

"Sure," Allison said, because the word came automatically. Because people expected agreement to sound like that.

Kara grinned, satisfied, and launched into a detailed rant about cap decorations without waiting for a response. Glitter versus vinyl. Quotes versus symbols. The moral implications of bedazzling.

Allison followed her down the hall, listening with half an ear, her attention snagging on small details she couldn't quite stop noticing. The way lockers slammed a little less hard than usual. The way a near-collision dissolved into apologies instead of anger. The way the noise of the hallway seemed to flatten when she passed through it, like sound deciding not to pile up.

She told herself she was overthinking it.

She told herself that a lot lately.

The hardest part about coming back to school wasn't fear.

It wasn't suspicion, either, or the creeping sense that something was stalking her from the edges of her awareness.

It was how **normal** everything looked.

Same scuffed floors. Same flickering lights that never quite got fixed. Same smell of cleaning solution layered over old paper and too many bodies moving through the same space every day. Someone had drawn a heart in Sharpie on the bathroom door again. Someone else had crossed it out and written **no** underneath.

The world had not paused to mark anything significant.

No one had drawn a line on the floor and said, **Here. This is where it changed.**

Allison had expected a break. A before and after she could point to and orient herself around. Some internal marker that would let her sort herself into categories:

before this and *after this*.

Instead, the world had simply... continued.

That made her feel like she was the one out of sync.

In English, the teacher sighed and rubbed her temple while two students argued about deadlines like it was a ritual both sides understood. The argument rose, crested, and then softened without ever tipping into something sharper. Allison watched it happen, a familiar tightening in her chest easing before she realized it had been there.

She waited for the feeling to come back.

It didn't.

She looked down at her desk, at the carved initials and half-scraped stickers layered over years of other students' boredom. The moment had passed without asking her permission.

In math, a boy a few rows over tapped his pencil against the desk, an irregular rhythm that pulled at her attention until she found herself counting the beats without meaning to. She lost count. Found it again. Let it go.

When she finally looked up, the tapping stopped.

He hadn't noticed her looking.

She was sure of it.

Still, the quiet that followed felt deliberate in a way she didn't have language for.

That kept happening.

Not dramatically. Not in ways anyone else commented on. Just small adjustments. Near-misses. Moments that could have escalated and didn't. A chair that scraped less loudly than it should have. A laugh that cut itself off before it turned sharp. The world choosing the less jagged version of itself in her vicinity again and again.

The calm followed her.

Not like a shield.

Like gravity.

Quiet. Constant. So familiar it was easy to forget it existed—until she tried to imagine what it would feel like if it suddenly disappeared.

At lunch, Kara spread out her phone and immediately launched into a debate about senior pictures. Emily leaned across the table to offer commentary that was half teasing, half earnest. Fries went cold. Someone spilled a drink and laughed instead of swearing.

Allison let herself be part of it.

She let the noise press in around her. Let the conversation drift past her without needing to hold onto every word. She watched Kara talk with her hands. Watched Emily roll her eyes at exactly the right moments. Watched herself nod and smile and exist in the space they made for her without asking questions.

Normal.

That was the goal. That had always been the goal.

“You’re doing that thing again,” Emily said, squinting at her.

Allison blinked. “What thing?”

“Watching,” Emily said. “Like you’re waiting for something to explode.”

Kara snorted. “Please. If something explodes this close to graduation, I’m suing the universe.”

Allison laughed, because it was easier than explaining that she wasn’t waiting for an explosion.

She was waiting for *proof*.

Proof that the calm would break. Proof that trusting it was a mistake. Proof that whatever had followed her back from that quiet place she refused to name wasn’t just a trick of perception.

None came.

The day stretched.

Classes ended. Lockers closed. The parking lot emptied in uneven waves. Allison took the long way home, cutting past the science wing where the windows reflected the sky like a second, flatter world. Her reflection moved when she did. Hoodie. Backpack. The same girl she’d been last month, last year.

Someone she could still recognize.

She paused for a moment before pushing through the doors, hand resting on the cool metal bar, and felt the strange weight of choosing to keep going instead of stopping to ask why.

At home, the afternoon stretched open in a way it hadn't in weeks. No obligations pressing at her back. No conversations she had to prepare for. Just time—quiet, ordinary, unclaimed.

It should have felt like relief.

Instead, it felt like standing at the edge of something and deciding not to step forward.

She drifted from room to room. Dropped her backpack by the door. Opened the fridge without being hungry. Let it close again. The house made its usual sounds: pipes ticking, the hum of the refrigerator, a car passing outside.

Nothing asked anything of her.

In her room, she sat on the edge of her bed and stared at her phone. The college email waited unopened, its subject line carefully neutral. She opened it. Read the first paragraph. Let her eyes skim without absorbing too much.

She closed it again.

Later, she told herself.

Later had become a safe word. A way to put distance between herself and decisions that felt heavier than they should.

She opened Notes and hovered over the checklist. The word *Normal* sat at the top, slightly crooked, like she'd typed it too fast the first time.

Her thumb moved before she fully decided to let it.

- Stay.

The word appeared beneath the others, small and plain. It didn't explain anything. It didn't promise anything. It just existed, quiet and stubborn.

Allison lay back on the bed and stared at the ceiling fan as it turned slow, steady circles. She counted the rotations once. Twice. Lost track and let it go.

She thought about leaving. About how easy it would be to frame it as momentum instead of avoidance. A future that didn't include this town, these halls, this watchful calm she didn't have language for.

Leaving would be a kind of control.

Staying, she realized, was something else.

It wasn't dramatic. It wasn't brave. It didn't feel like a stand.

It felt like choosing not to be moved.

When she went back out into the world the next day—back to school, back to routines, back to the ordinary rhythms that had shaped her long before any of this—the calm followed.

And somewhere nearby, though no one said anything about it, someone noticed that the world had settled

again.

Allison didn't feel powerful.

She felt steady.

And in a world that seemed to expect escalation,
steadiness felt like its own quiet defiance.

Chapter 25 — What Isn't Being Said

Allison didn't decide to go to Evan's house so much as realize she was already heading there.

The thought surfaced halfway down the block, too formed to ignore but not sharp enough to feel like a choice. Her backpack was slung over one shoulder. Her phone was still in her hand, screen dark. She slowed for a moment, considering turning back, then didn't.

Evan's house had always felt... neutral. Not hers. Not school. A place where things tended to stay what they were.

That mattered.

Evan opened the door before she knocked. He looked surprised, then relieved, like both reactions had been waiting to see which one would win.

"Hey," he said. "Everything okay?"

"I think so," Allison said, and meant *I don't know, but nothing is wrong yet*.

Inside, the house carried its usual smells—coffee that had been sitting too long, something warm starting on the stove, clean laundry somewhere nearby. The television murmured softly from another room, low enough to feel more like background presence than sound.

Evan's dad was at the counter with a stack of mail, sorting it without urgency. Mara stood at the stove,

stirring slowly, unhurried.

No one stopped what they were doing when Allison came in.

No one watched her too closely.

That, more than anything, made her feel like she could speak.

“You’re welcome to stay a bit,” Mara said easily.

“Dinner won’t be ready for a while.”

“Thanks,” Allison said. “I just... needed to talk for a minute.”

Evan glanced at her, searching her face, then nodded and led her into the living room. They sat on the couch, not quite touching. Evan’s dad joined them, coffee mug in hand, settling into the chair across from them like this was the sort of conversation that happened all the time.

Allison clasped her hands together, then let them fall apart again. The silence stretched, waiting.

“So,” she said finally. “This might sound weird.”

Evan gave a small smile. “That’s kind of our thing lately.”

She almost smiled back.

“It feels like things keep... accommodating me,” she said, testing the word as she spoke it. “Like when something should turn into a problem, it just doesn’t.”

She paused, checking their faces.

Evan was listening closely, brows slightly drawn together. His dad's expression stayed open, unreadable. Mara kept stirring, her attention angled toward the conversation without fully turning into it.

"Teachers ease off," Allison continued. "Arguments stop before they really start. Situations smooth out instead of getting complicated."

She took a breath. "At first I thought it was coincidence. Or luck. Or me finally not making everything worse."

Evan shifted, but didn't interrupt.

"But it keeps happening," she said. "And I've tried to refuse it."

That was when Mara stopped stirring.

Not abruptly. Just enough that the motion ended.

"Tried how?" Evan asked.

"By not leaning into it," Allison said. "By choosing normal things. Staying. Not asking for exceptions. Not... pushing."

Her voice dropped a little. "It still happens."

The room settled into a quiet that didn't feel awkward so much as deliberate.

Mara turned then, wiping her hands on a towel as she faced them. She met Allison's eyes—and something subtle changed. Not alarm. Not concern.

Recognition.

Her gaze flicked briefly to Evan's dad.

He met it immediately.

It was a small thing. A fraction of a second. But it was practiced, and it was aligned.

Allison saw it.

Evan saw Allison see it.

"What was that?" Evan asked.

Mara looked back at him. "What do you mean?"

"That," he said, nodding toward both of them. "You just... did something."

Allison swallowed. "You know what I'm talking about."

The silence that followed was different. Thicker. Less accidental.

Mara set the towel down and sat across from them, folding her hands together in her lap. She didn't rush.

"We're listening," she said.

"That's not the same thing as answering," Evan said.

"No," Mara agreed quietly. "It isn't."

Allison felt something in her chest tighten—not fear, exactly. Pressure. Like leaning against a door and realizing there was weight on the other side.

"You're not telling me I'm wrong," she said.

“No,” Mara said.

“And you’re not explaining why,” Allison added.

“No,” Mara said again.

The honesty of it landed harder than denial would have.

Evan leaned forward, elbows on his knees. “So what aren’t you telling us?”

His dad exhaled slowly, the sound barely audible.

“There are things,” he said, choosing each word with care, “that we don’t talk about until it’s necessary.”

“Allison just said they *are* necessary,” Evan said.

“She said they’re happening,” Mara corrected gently.

“That’s not always the same thing.”

Allison felt a flicker of irritation—and recognized it wasn’t directed at her.

“Is this about me?” she asked.

“Yes,” Mara said immediately.

That answer came without hesitation.

“But not in a way that requires you to change what you’re doing,” Mara continued. “And not in a way that puts you in danger.”

“Are we in danger?” Allison asked.

“No,” Evan’s dad said at once.

Evan glanced between them. “Are you?”

Mara smiled faintly. “No.”

Allison let that settle. “So you’re choosing not to tell us.”

“Yes,” Mara said.

“Why?”

Mara paused.

“Because you’re doing exactly what you should be doing,” she said. “And because explaining would interfere with that.”

Allison absorbed that slowly.

“So I just... keep going,” she said.

“For now,” Mara said.

Evan shook his head. “That’s not fair.”

“No,” Mara agreed. “It isn’t. But it is careful.”

Allison stood, the movement sudden but not angry. “I didn’t come here for answers,” she said. “I just needed to know if I was imagining things.”

Mara met her gaze steadily. “You aren’t.”

That was it. That was all.

Outside, the air felt cooler than she expected. Evan walked her partway home, the silence between them companionable but heavy.

They walked in silence for a bit.

Evan slowed without saying anything. Allison didn't notice at first—only realized when she nearly bumped into him.

"You okay?" he asked.

She nodded automatically, then stopped herself. "I don't know," she said quietly.

Evan hesitated, just long enough to make it a choice, then reached out and took her hand. His fingers were warm, steady. He didn't squeeze. He didn't say anything.

Allison let out a breath she hadn't realized she was holding.

They stood there like that for a moment, the quiet stretching around them without turning sharp. Evan shifted closer, his arm coming around her shoulders in a way that felt more protective than possessive, like he was bracing rather than claiming.

She leaned into him without thinking.

For a few seconds, the world narrowed to the simple fact of not being alone.

"They could've said more," Evan muttered eventually, kicking a pebble ahead of them.

"They could've," Allison agreed.

"But they didn't."

"No."

They walked in silence for another block.

“If you want me to ask again,” Evan said finally, “I will.”

She considered the offer. The look. The calm that had settled instead of tightening.

“Not yet,” she said.

Evan nodded. “Okay.”

The quiet followed her the rest of the way home.

And now she knew it wasn’t accidental.

Chapter 25 — I Don't Know

Evan didn't sleep much.

Not because he expected something to happen—he didn't even know what **something** would look like. His mind just kept circling the same moments, over and over, like they were pieces of a puzzle he wasn't allowed to see the picture for.

The look his parents had exchanged.

Allison's face when she realized she'd seen it.

The way she'd gone still, then steadied, like she was making a decision without knowing what all the options were.

And later, outside, when she'd leaned into him without thinking.

That moment stayed with him the longest. Not because it meant anything he could explain, but because it hadn't tried to. It hadn't asked him to understand or define or fix anything.

It had just been there.

Comfort without interpretation.

Morning arrived anyway, pale and ordinary. The kitchen smelled like coffee and toast. Mara stood at the counter slicing fruit into a bowl, the knife moving in slow, even strokes. Jonah sat at the table scrolling through the news on his tablet, one hand wrapped around a mug that had already gone untouched for a

while.

Neither of them looked tired.

That bothered Evan more than it should have.

He poured himself coffee and stood there longer than necessary, watching steam curl up from the mug and disappear. He waited for one of them to say something—to acknowledge that last night hadn't ended cleanly, that something was hanging in the air.

Nothing happened.

"Did you sleep?" Mara asked without looking up.

"Not really," Evan said.

She nodded once. No apology. No reassurance. Just acknowledgment, like she'd expected that answer and filed it away.

Silence settled into the space between them. Not awkward. Deliberate.

"You knew," Evan said finally.

Mara's knife paused for a fraction of a second, then continued. "Evan—"

"No," he said, sharper than he meant. He took a breath and tried again. "Last night. You both knew what Allison was talking about."

Jonah set the tablet down and folded his hands on the table. He didn't look defensive. He didn't look surprised. He just looked ready.

“We recognized what she described,” Mara said. “Yes.”

“So you know what’s happening to her.”

Mara met his eyes. She didn’t soften the answer. “We know more than she does.”

Evan felt something tighten low in his chest. “That’s not an answer.”

“It’s the only one we’re giving you right now,” Jonah said calmly.

“Why?” Evan asked.

Mara set the knife down and turned fully toward him, resting her hands on the counter. “Because if we tell you more, you won’t be able to hold it neutrally.”

Evan frowned. “Neutrally?”

“You care,” she said simply. “That means anything you know would leak into how you talk to her. How you look at her. What you think she should do next.”

“I already care,” Evan said.

“Yes,” Jonah said. “But right now, you don’t *interpret*.”

“That feels like a technicality.”

“It isn’t,” Mara said. “It’s the difference between being present and steering.”

Evan leaned back against the counter, crossing his arms, trying to anchor himself to something solid. “She trusted us.”

“Yes,” Mara said. “And we didn’t lie to her.”

“It still feels wrong.”

Mara’s expression softened—not yielding, not apologizing. Just acknowledging the weight of what he was saying. “It is uncomfortable,” she said. “That doesn’t make it wrong.”

Evan swallowed. “I don’t even know what I’m supposed to do.”

“That,” Mara said gently, “is exactly where you’re supposed to be.”

He stared at her. “You want me to do nothing.”

“No,” Jonah said. “We want you to do less than you want to.”

Evan let out a short, humorless laugh. “That’s not reassuring.”

“It isn’t meant to be,” Mara said. “It’s meant to be honest.”

Evan looked down at his hands. He hadn’t realized how tightly he’d curled them until he forced his fingers to relax.

“I want to help her,” he said quietly.

“I know,” Mara said.

“And you’re telling me not to.”

“I’m telling you not to explain something you don’t understand,” Mara corrected. “If she asks what it

means, you don't guess. You don't fill the silence because it makes you uncomfortable."

His throat tightened. "I say I don't know."

Mara nodded once. "Exactly."

The simplicity of it hit harder than any lecture could have. Saying *I don't know* felt like failure. Like stepping back when every instinct told him to move forward.

But maybe that instinct was the problem.

At school, Evan found Allison at her locker, her forehead resting briefly against the metal before she straightened. She looked up when she noticed him, and something in her expression eased immediately—like she'd been holding tension in place and could let it loosen, just a little.

"Hey," she said.

"Hey."

They walked toward class together, shoulders nearly brushing in the crowded hallway. Evan matched his pace to hers without thinking.

"How are you?" he asked.

Allison considered the question longer than most people would. "Okay," she said. "Not great. Not bad. Just... okay."

Evan nodded. That made sense. *Okay* felt like a holding pattern.

“Do you think I’m imagining things?” she asked suddenly.

The question landed softly, but Evan felt its weight immediately. He could feel words lining up behind his teeth, explanations he didn’t have, reassurances he wasn’t qualified to give.

He let them go.

“No,” he said.

Allison glanced at him, surprised. “You didn’t even hesitate.”

“I believe you,” Evan said. He paused, choosing the rest carefully. “I just don’t know what it means.”

Allison studied his face, searching for something—certainty, maybe, or direction. Whatever it was, she didn’t find it.

Instead, she nodded.

“That’s fair,” she said.

They walked the rest of the way in silence, the noise of the school flowing around them. Evan stayed where he was—beside her, not ahead of her, not pulling her toward any conclusion he couldn’t stand behind.

Observer only.

And for the first time, that didn’t feel like doing nothing.

Chapter 25 — Direction

Allison told herself she was just going to the store.

Not for anything important or complicated—just toothpaste, paper towels, and maybe, if she felt like it, one of those overpriced iced coffees that tasted like sugar and regret. Small things. Ordinary things. The kind of errand that made a day feel like a day instead of a waiting room.

She left the house with her keys in her hand out of habit, then shoved them into her pocket when she realized she didn't need them. The air outside was cold enough to wake her up fully, sharp against her face, pulling her attention outward whether she wanted it to or not.

The street looked the same as it always did. Cars lined the curb. A dog barked somewhere behind a fence. Someone's wind chimes tapped softly and then went still as the breeze faded.

Nothing waited for her. That mattered.

She started walking, letting the rhythm of her steps carry her forward while she tried not to think about anything at all. Not in a deliberate way—just a quiet refusal to let her thoughts line up and start demanding answers. She didn't want to think about the calm, or the way adults had gone quiet when she talked, or the sense that something had shifted without ever being named. She just wanted the day to be a day, something ordinary she could move through without examining it too

closely.

Halfway down the block, she felt it again—a faint internal click, like stepping into a room and realizing someone had already counted how many people were inside.

Not watched. Not followed.

Just accounted for.

She slowed and turned slightly, scanning the street as if movement itself might reveal something she'd missed. It didn't. A woman across the road dragged a trash bin back toward her garage, wheels rattling against the concrete. A kid rode a bike near the corner, wobbling as he practiced wide, uneven turns.

Everything continued.

Allison told herself that if nothing looked different, nothing was different, and kept walking.

The strip of shops sat a few blocks down, close enough to feel like part of her neighborhood instead of a destination. A pharmacy, a convenience store, a coffee place that tried a little too hard to look like it belonged somewhere trendier. The sidewalk was uneven where tree roots pushed up from underneath, and Allison stepped over the worst of it without thinking, passing the same yard with the ceramic frog that always looked like it was judging her and the same porch with a faded flag that never seemed to move even when the wind did.

Familiar. Predictable.

At the intersection, a car rolled through the stop sign too fast—the kind of thing that usually ended in a honk or a sharp look exchanged through windshields. Instead, the driver corrected smoothly and moved on, the near-problem dissolving before it could finish forming.

Allison felt her shoulders tighten anyway. She told herself she was only noticing because she'd trained herself to notice lately, and that noticing didn't automatically mean anything.

Inside the pharmacy, warmth wrapped around her immediately, the smell of cleaner and paper and something faintly medicinal settling into her nose. Fluorescent lights flattened everything into the same bright sameness. She moved quickly, as if speed alone could keep the errand uncomplicated—straight to toothpaste, then paper towels, then a pack of gum she didn't need but added anyway.

She slowed at the refrigerated drinks. The iced coffee she wanted sat behind a plastic divider, lined up neatly. She reached for it and stopped when she saw the sign taped to the glass.

****OUT OF ORDER — PLEASE USE OTHER COOLER****

She stared at it longer than necessary. The cooler hummed softly, quieter than it should have been, its interior light flickering once before settling. The other cooler sat at the front of the store, wedged beside a seasonal display that felt out of place for the time of year.

It wasn't blocked. It wasn't denied. It was just farther.

She hesitated, then told herself not to be ridiculous and walked over. The iced coffee was there—same brand, same flavor—and she took one and headed for the register, faintly annoyed at herself for having paused at all.

The line moved slowly. A man in a work jacket stood at the counter, politely frustrated about a coupon that wouldn't scan. The cashier listened patiently, fingers hovering over the keys. Allison felt the air tighten, the familiar sense of this-is-where-it-tips.

It didn't.

The cashier typed something in manually. The man's shoulders relaxed, relief plain in his posture, and he thanked her twice before moving aside. The tension dissolved without leaving residue, and Allison shifted her weight, unsettled by how cleanly it had ended.

When it was her turn, the cashier smiled. "Did you find everything okay?"

"Yeah," Allison said automatically, then hesitated. "Mostly."

The cashier tilted her head. "Mostly?"

Allison considered explaining—pointing out the broken cooler, the longer walk, the small inconvenience—but instead shrugged. "Things move around."

The cashier laughed. "Keeps you from getting too comfortable."

The words landed harder than they should have.

Outside again, the cold bit at her face. Allison stood for a moment with the bag cutting into her fingers, grounding herself in the sharp pull of plastic against skin. She could go home now; she had what she came for.

The coffee shop was only a few doors down.

She started toward it and stopped short at the sign on the door.

****CLOSED — STAFFING ISSUE — BACK AT 4:00****

She checked her phone. It wasn't three yet. Through the glass she could see the lights on, chairs stacked on tables as if the place had been shut down in a hurry.

It made sense. It also made this the third time she'd adjusted course in less than an hour.

She stepped back.

Across the street, the library sat solid and familiar, a quiet constant. She hadn't planned to go there, but it was open—available in a way the other places suddenly weren't. She crossed at the light and pushed through the heavy doors.

Inside, the smell of old paper and carpet cleaner wrapped around her. A librarian glanced up and smiled automatically.

“Hi.”

“Hi,” Allison replied, heading toward the back tables where the quiet felt communal instead of lonely.

A rolling cart of books narrowed the aisle—not blocking it, just enough to require adjustment. Allison turned sideways to pass, and the cart wobbled just enough to trigger instinct. Her hand shot out before she could think, fingers pressing against the cold metal until the motion stilled. There was no crash, no sound, no sudden attention drawn her way; the moment resolved itself quietly, as if it had never been on the verge of becoming anything else.

She stood there for a second longer than necessary, then moved on without trying to explain it.

At a table near the wall, she unwrapped the iced coffee and took a sip. It was too sweet, comfortingly familiar. She drank half of it before realizing she’d been staring at the same faint scratches in the tabletop the entire time.

Only then did she notice how tired she felt—not from walking, but from adjusting. From choosing the easier path over and over without ever consciously deciding to.

Near the front desk, a man she didn’t recognize spoke quietly with the librarian. Nothing urgent, nothing dramatic. The librarian nodded once, her gaze flicking briefly toward Allison before returning to the man.

His eyes followed.

They passed over Allison and paused—not long enough to call attention to it, but long enough to feel like acknowledgment.

Allison looked down at her cup.

A few minutes later, she left.

The walk home followed the same route. The same cracks in the sidewalk. The same ceramic frog. The same quiet street. But the day felt different now—not hostile or dangerous, just subtly guided, like the world had begun favoring certain directions over others.

Allison tightened her grip on the bag and kept walking, telling herself she was choosing the way home, even as the world continued to make the other directions slightly harder.

Chapter 25 — The Easier Option

Allison woke before her alarm and stayed that way longer than she meant to.

The house was already awake around her—the clink of dishes in the kitchen, the muted cadence of the morning news, the familiar rhythm of Emily's footsteps on the stairs. Ordinary sounds, the kind that usually told her everything was fine without needing to say it.

Today they felt louder. Not threatening. Just... present.

She rolled onto her side and stared at the wall until the urge to stay still started to feel heavier than the effort of moving. When she finally got up, the routine carried her more than intention did: shower, clothes, cereal eaten standing at the counter because sitting felt like it might slow her down too much.

Sunlight slanted through the kitchen window, bright but not hot yet, catching on the edge of the table and the sink faucet. It had that late-spring quality that made mornings feel forgiving, as if the day was offering her a chance to ease into it.

Emily came in halfway through, hair still damp, phone in hand.

"You're up early," Emily said.

Allison shrugged. "Couldn't sleep."

Emily glanced at her—not long enough to make it a thing, just enough to register—and then looked back at

her screen. “You want to walk to school?”

They didn’t do that every day. Sometimes they walked home together if the afternoon was nice, but mornings were usually rushed and separate, each of them slipping into their own routines without thinking much about it.

Allison hesitated, the pause small but real. “Sure.”

They grabbed light jackets more out of habit than necessity and stepped outside. The air was already warm enough that Allison knew she’d regret the extra layer later, carrying that unsettled late-spring mix of sun and cool shade that never quite picked a side.

A neighbor was watering their lawn, the smell of damp grass hanging faintly in the air. Somewhere down the street, a window was open with music playing low.

They walked in silence for the first block, their steps falling out of sync before gradually smoothing into something shared.

“You okay?” Emily asked eventually, eyes forward.

Allison considered the question. “Yeah.”

Emily hummed softly. “That wasn’t convincing.”

“I’m just tired,” Allison said. It wasn’t a lie. It just wasn’t the whole truth.

Emily nudged a pebble along the sidewalk with her shoe. “You’ve been tired a lot.”

Allison didn’t answer. The quiet between them wasn’t uncomfortable—it was the kind they’d grown up with,

where silence didn't demand explanation.

"You don't have to tell me," Emily added after a moment. "I'm just checking."

Allison nodded, grateful for that more than she could have said.

The school building came into view sooner than Allison expected, brick bright in the sunlight, doors already swallowing students whole.

At the entrance, Emily slowed. "We'll walk home later?"

"Yeah," Allison said, and meant it.

Inside, the building felt warmer, louder. Lockers slammed. Voices overlapped. Someone laughed too hard on purpose. Kara appeared at Allison's locker with her usual momentum, like the day had already agreed to keep up with her.

"We're eating lunch outside," Kara announced. "It's actually decent out, which feels suspicious, but I'm choosing to trust it."

Allison smiled faintly. "Maybe."

Kara narrowed her eyes. "That's not a yes."

"I just have some stuff to finish," Allison said.

"Okay," Kara replied easily, already half-turned toward someone else. "We'll see you if you show."

The words were casual. The absence of pressure should have felt like relief.

It didn't.

The morning passed quietly until English. Near the end of the period, her teacher paused while handing out papers and looked up.

"Allison, could you stay for a minute after class?"

The request was polite, almost offhand, but Allison felt that familiar tightening in her chest anyway.

When the bell rang, the room emptied quickly. Allison stayed seated, hands folded on her notebook, watching the dust settle back into place.

Her teacher smiled. "Nothing bad."

Allison nodded. "Okay."

"I wanted to tell you your last paper was one of the strongest in the class," the teacher continued. "You have a really grounded voice. You don't overreach. You don't try to impress anyone. You just say what you mean."

The praise landed gently and still managed to knock her off balance. Compliments always did that—made her feel seen from an angle she hadn't agreed to show.

"We're doing peer review next week," the teacher said, "and I thought you might lead a small group."

Allison's stomach tightened.

“It’s not a big responsibility,” the teacher added quickly. “Just keeping the conversation focused. You’re calm. You’re steady. People listen to you.”

Allison stared at the edge of her desk, at the faint scratch someone had carved there years ago and never finished.

It wasn’t unreasonable. It wasn’t framed as obligation. It was the kind of opportunity that sounded sensible when adults talked about it later.

“I’d rather not,” Allison said carefully.

The teacher’s smile didn’t disappear, but it smoothed, like water choosing an easier path. “Of course,” she said. “We can talk about it again if you change your mind.”

The implication lingered longer than the conversation itself.

By lunchtime, the sun was high enough to warm the concrete outside, the air thick with that end-of-semester restlessness that made everything feel slightly louder. Allison texted Kara that she was heading to the library instead.

Kara replied with a thumbs-up and nothing else.

The easier option.

The library was quiet and predictable, and Allison finished her work faster than she expected. When she left, the afternoon stretched ahead of her without shape or demand.

She walked home early.

The neighborhood was quieter than it should have been at that hour, late-spring sunlight stretching across driveways and lawns. When she unlocked the door and stepped inside, the house greeted her with nothing at all.

No voices.

No movement upstairs.

No one asking how her day went.

She stood there longer than necessary, keys still in her hand, listening just to be sure. Nothing answered.

Allison dropped her bag by the stairs and went into the living room, sitting on the couch where the light slanted across the cushions. This was usually the part of the day that still belonged to school in small ways—finishing a conversation, walking home with Emily, letting the day taper instead of end.

Now it stopped all at once.

She leaned back and stared at the ceiling fan without turning it on, watching the light shift as clouds passed outside. Choosing the easier option hadn't felt dramatic. It had felt sensible.

Sitting here, it felt different.

Not wrong.

Just... thinner.

The front door opened twenty minutes later.

“I’m home,” Emily called.

Allison stayed where she was until Emily appeared in the doorway and paused.

“You’re already home,” Emily said.

Allison nodded. “Yeah.”

Emily frowned slightly, more confused than upset.

“You said we’d walk home together.”

The words landed harder than Allison expected.

“I didn’t feel like staying,” Allison said quietly.

Emily set her backpack down and leaned against the wall, studying her the way only a younger sister could—direct, unfiltered, familiar enough not to soften the truth.

“You could’ve texted,” Emily said. Not accusing. Just stating it.

“I know,” Allison said.

They stood there for a moment, the missed walk hanging between them, not big enough to argue about but too real to ignore.

“It was just easier,” Allison added, like that might explain it.

Emily considered that. “Did it help?”

Allison thought about the quiet house, the empty afternoon, the way the day had folded inward without ever pushing back.

“I don’t know,” she said. “It didn’t make anything worse.”

Emily nodded slowly. “That’s not the same thing.”

Allison leaned back against the couch, letting the late-spring warmth settle through the windows. Choosing the easier option hadn’t broken anything.

It had just cost her something small and ordinary.

And she wasn’t sure yet how many of those she was willing to lose.

15.5 — Counterfactual Confirmation

The room was built for clarity.

It had no windows and no ornamentation. The surfaces were pale and matte, chosen to hold attention without reflecting it. The table at the center was unremarkable except for its placement, positioned with a precision that suggested alignment mattered here, even when no one spoke of it.

Three people stood around it. No one sat. There was no need.

The projection had already resolved by the time they arrived.

It hovered above the table in thin, steady layers—branching paths rendered with restrained color, each gradient marking escalation, diffusion, or collapse. This was not speculative work. It was comparative, designed to answer a single, well-defined question:

What should have happened?

The woman closest to the table rested her hands lightly against its surface. She had overseen this process countless times. It was familiar enough to be almost routine, which was why she did not expect resistance.

“Baseline,” she said.

The projection adjusted smoothly, one branch brightening as the rest receded. The sequence unfolded with practiced inevitability: initiating conditions,

threshold crossings, secondary effects. Nothing extreme. Nothing unprecedented.

“This pattern has held across prior assessments,” one of the others said. “The initiating conditions were present. Emotional density exceeded tolerance. External stressors aligned. Proximity was sufficient.”

Another voice, quieter but no less certain, followed. “The cascade should have initiated at this point.”

The projection marked the node. From it, multiple paths extended, narrowing and widening toward outcomes shaded in amber and red. Increased conflict. Secondary involvement. Containment measures. The projected cost was real, but bounded.

Responsible. Predictable.

“And the probability band?” the woman asked.

“Seventy-eight to eighty-four percent,” came the reply. “Variance within acceptable limits.”

She inclined her head. “Confirm observation.”

The projection shifted again. The highlighted branch dimmed, its expected progression dissolving as the system overlaid actual results.

“Observed outcome does not correspond to any modeled sequence,” one voice reported.

There was a brief pause—not alarm, not disbelief, but recalibration.

“Show divergence,” the woman said.

“That’s the issue,” the other replied. “There isn’t one.”

She pressed her palms more firmly against the table.

“Clarify.”

“In prior deviations, alternate branches emerge. Suppression leaves artifacts. Intervention leaves residue.” A measured breath. “Here, the initiating sequence never appears.”

The projection tightened, zooming in on the precise point where escalation should have begun.

There was nothing.

Not absence in the sense of removal.

Absence in the sense of non-occurrence.

She straightened. “Re-run with adjusted sensitivity.”

“It’s already at maximum ethical allowance.”

“Cross-check against independent projections.”

“Completed. Same result.”

Silence settled into the room, deliberate and unhurried. This was not the silence of uncertainty, but of confirmation.

“The outcome was not prevented,” the woman said at last.

“No,” another voice agreed. “There is no evidence of prevention.”

“It did not resolve early?”

“No.”

“Redirect?”

“No.”

“Delayed?”

“No.”

The final voice spoke carefully. “The initiating conditions were present. The sequence was valid. The cost was projected. But the process did not begin.”

The woman nodded once, slowly, and dismissed the projection with a small gesture. The light faded, leaving the table bare.

“Record this as verified absence,” she said. “Flag it for ethical escalation.”

She paused, then added—quietly, precisely—

“Absence does not imply safety.”

There was no objection. No raised voices. Only acknowledgment.

“And concealment?” someone asked.

She considered the question—not as a matter of authority, but of responsibility.

“Continued concealment may increase harm,” she said. “Non-disclosure no longer minimizes risk.”

She turned away from the table. “Observation alone is no longer sufficient.”

Behind her, the room returned to stillness. The space where the outcome should have been remained empty.

And now that emptiness had been confirmed—and named—it began to matter.

Chapter 25 — Assumption

Allison noticed it first because it didn't wait for her.

The day moved the way days always did—too fast in the morning, slower by afternoon—but somewhere between second period and lunch, she became aware of a small, quiet dislocation. A moment had already finished happening. Not ended exactly. More like it had reached a conclusion without pausing to see if she was ready.

She stood in the hallway with her bag slipping down one shoulder, watching people stream past her, and tried to name the feeling. There should have been a hesitation. Someone stopping mid-sentence. A glance exchanged. A subtle opening where she could step in and nudge things, even slightly, off their track.

Instead, the hallway flowed around her like water around a stone—efficient, unbothered. A decision had been made somewhere nearby, and it hadn't required her attention. That was what unsettled her most: not that she'd missed it, but that it had proceeded as though her presence were incidental.

"Hey," Kara said, appearing at her side. "You coming?"

Allison blinked, pulled back into motion. "Where?"

Kara tilted her head. "We're heading out early. Assembly got moved. Didn't you hear?"

"No," Allison said. The word felt heavier than it should have.

“They announced it at the start of class,” Kara said with a shrug, already half-turned as if this were settled.

Allison searched her memory. The bell. The scrape of chairs. The teacher clearing her throat. She remembered opening her notebook, the steady drag of her pen across the page, the comfort of routine.

She didn’t remember the announcement.

“Are you okay?” Kara asked, pausing just long enough to check.

“Yeah,” Allison said automatically. “Just—thinking.”

Kara smiled and started walking again. “Same. Come on.”

They moved toward the doors together, the noise of lockers and voices thinning behind them. Outside, the air was warm in that late-spring way that felt almost generous, like the day were offering something freely.

Allison breathed it in, waiting for the familiar easing that usually followed moments like this—waiting for her body to reassure her that everything was still aligned.

It didn’t.

The feeling wasn’t panic or fear. It was quieter than that, stranger. Like the instant after you miss a step on the stairs and realize you’ve already caught yourself. Relief should have followed.

Instead, there was only awareness.

The day hadn't stumbled. It had continued cleanly, without correction.

By lunch, the tables filled quickly, voices rising and overlapping in familiar patterns.

Allison arrived last, tray balanced carefully in her hands. She scanned the table, found an open seat near the end, and slid into it, setting her tray down with deliberate care, as if precision might anchor her to the moment.

Conversation flowed around her—weekend plans, homework complaints, someone laughing too loudly at something that probably wasn't that funny. She listened, nodded when it felt appropriate, smiled when it seemed expected, but the sense of being slightly out of step lingered.

Kara leaned across the table. "Jess and I are heading out after school."

Allison looked up. "Oh."

"Yeah," Kara said. "We talked about it in chem. Nothing big."

Allison nodded slowly. Yesterday's loose conversation surfaced in her mind—the walk, the maybe, the way the plan had felt safe because it hadn't been fixed to anything solid.

"I'll probably just head home," Allison said, the words settling easily once she said them.

Kara smiled and turned back to her food. "Cool."

That was it. No pause. No negotiation. The plan reshaped itself smoothly, closing the space Allison left behind without resistance, as if it had always been prepared to do so.

She ate quietly after that, barely tasting the food. When the bell rang, everyone stood at once, chairs scraping, trays clattering, the moment dispersing all at once.

Allison stayed seated a beat longer, watching the empty place Kara had occupied.

The absence didn't ache.

It settled.

Evan caught up with her near the bike racks as she was leaving campus.

He didn't hurry or call her name. He simply fell into step beside her, matching her pace without comment, as though this were the most natural continuation of the afternoon.

"You heading home?" he asked.

"Yeah," Allison said. "I think so."

He adjusted the strap of his backpack. "Mind if I walk with you?"

She glanced at him, then ahead. "Sure."

They walked in easy silence, the sounds of the school fading behind them. The neighborhood felt quieter, the afternoon light softer, stretching across the pavement in long, unhurried lines.

After a block, Evan spoke again. "You seemed quiet today."

Allison let out a breath she hadn't realized she'd been holding. "I'm always quiet."

"Yeah," he said. "But this was different."

She smiled faintly. "You're very observant."

He shrugged. "I notice stuff."

She waited for him to explain, then realized he wasn't going to. The quiet held, comfortable rather than pressing.

"I think," she said slowly, feeling her way through the words, "things are just... happening."

He glanced at her, attentive but unalarmed. "That's usually how things work."

"No," Allison said, a little more firmly. "Before, it felt like there was time. Like if I waited, things would wait with me."

He didn't interrupt. His steps stayed even, unhurried, giving her space without pulling away.

"And now?" he asked.

"Now it feels like the waiting part is over."

They reached the corner where their paths usually split. Allison slowed without intending to, and Evan slowed with her, unconsciously matching the change.

“Is that bad?” he asked.

“I don’t know,” she said. “It’s not wrong. Just different.”

He nodded. “Different doesn’t have to mean dangerous.”

It wasn’t reassurance. He wasn’t promising anything.

He was just there.

“I’m not going anywhere,” he said, almost casually. Then, after a beat, “Not today, anyway.”

Something in Allison’s chest loosened—not relief, not comfort exactly, but recognition.

“Thanks,” she said.

They stood there a moment longer, the afternoon stretching quietly around them. A car door closed somewhere nearby. A dog barked. Life continued, orderly and intact.

“I’ll see you tomorrow?” Evan said.

“Yeah,” Allison said. “Tomorrow.”

He turned and headed down his street. Allison watched him go before continuing toward home.

As she walked, she tried to name what had changed.

The world still felt calm. Balanced. Reasonable.

But it no longer leaned toward her. It moved forward confidently, assuming she would follow—or not—without needing to check.

Allison reached her front door with that thought still with her.

Things were happening.

And for the first time, they weren't waiting to see what she would do about it.

Chapter 25 — Alignment

The changes didn't arrive all at once.

That was what made them harder to track.

If something had gone wrong—if a rule had been broken or a line crossed—Allison thought she would have felt it immediately. There would have been a jolt, a clean break where before and after separated neatly. She would have known which moment to point to.

Instead, the day kept moving, and things simply began fitting together a little too well.

It started with her schedule.

Not the classes themselves, but the spaces between them. Hallway crossings shortened. The usual bottlenecks dissolved before she reached them. Where she used to arrive early or late, she now arrived exactly when she needed to. Doors opened as her hand lifted. Teachers finished sentences as she found her seat.

At first, it felt like luck.

Then it felt like pattern.

By the second day, it felt intentional.

She noticed it in small ways: the way the hallway quieted just enough for her footsteps to echo, the way a cluster of students shifted without looking as she approached, the way a conversation ended right as she passed, leaving behind a pocket of silence that closed again once she was through.

No one reacted.

That was the unsettling part.

She tried to interrupt it once, just to see what would happen.

After English, she lingered at her locker longer than necessary, pretending to reorganize her bag. She waited for the familiar friction—the rush afterward, the sharp looks, the mild consequence of being late.

Nothing came.

When she finally headed toward her next class, the hallway was nearly empty, as though it had already decided she would take her time. She walked unhurried, the floor cool beneath her shoes, the fluorescent lights humming softly overhead.

When she reached the door, it opened.

Inside, the class settled into quiet just as she slid into her seat.

No looks. No comments.

It was as if she had arrived exactly when she was expected.

The thought followed her through the rest of the morning, threading itself through every small interaction, and by lunch it had started to change how everything else felt.

The cafeteria smelled the same—overheated food, cleaning solution, something fried—but the sound felt

different. More even. Less sharp. Allison scanned the tables and found the open seat near the end without having to look for it.

She slid into place.

People filled in around her without comment, conversations adjusting smoothly without requiring her input. She listened. She nodded. She stayed.

No one waited for her to steer things.

Kara glanced at her once, mid-conversation, smiled, and turned back to Jess. Not checking. Not asking.

Just adjusting.

The realization settled heavily in Allison's chest: the world wasn't reacting to her anymore.

It was accounting for her.

She pulled her phone from her pocket while the others talked and opened her notes app.

****Notes — Don't forget****

- Things feel easier, but not lighter
- Timing keeps working out *without me trying*
- Check if I'm choosing anything, or just arriving

She locked her phone and slipped it back into her pocket. The conversation around her flowed on,

uninterrupted.

That awareness stayed with her through the rest of the afternoon, sharpening rather than fading, and by the time Evan caught up to her after school she was already holding the words in her mouth, unsure how to shape them.

They walked together, their steps falling into the same quiet rhythm as the day before. The street felt narrower somehow, houses leaning closer, shadows stretching longer across the pavement.

“You feel weird,” Evan said, not accusing. Just observant.

Allison huffed a short laugh. “Is that your official diagnosis?”

He smiled. “No. Just an observation.”

She thought about brushing it off, but the sense of alignment pressed against her ribs, insistent.

“Do you ever get the feeling,” she asked slowly, “that things are... adjusting?”

“Adjusting how?”

“Like they’ve already decided where you’re going to be,” she said. “And they’re just making it easier to get there.”

Evan considered that. “That sounds... convenient.”

“That’s the problem,” she said. “It feels like convenience without choice.”

They walked another half block, the quiet stretching comfortably between them.

“Do you want it to stop?” he asked.

She opened her mouth, then closed it again.

“I don’t know,” she admitted. “I just want to notice it without agreeing to it.”

He nodded, as if that distinction mattered. “Then notice it.”

“That’s it?”

“That’s enough for now.”

The answer didn’t solve anything, but it stayed with her, echoing quietly, all the way home.

The next morning, Allison woke before her alarm.

Not startled. Not anxious.

Just... ready.

Sunlight filtered through the curtains at exactly the right angle to wake her without blinding her. She lay there for a moment, staring at the ceiling, thinking about noticing without agreeing, about what it meant to stay awake inside a day that seemed eager to carry her.

She didn’t feel rushed.

That frightened her more than panic ever had.

Downstairs, breakfast unfolded with the same quiet efficiency. Emily was already dressed, backpack by the

door. Their mom moved easily through the kitchen, coffee poured, lunches packed.

No one waited.

Allison slid into her seat and ate, the routine closing around her like something long-practiced.

Too well-practiced.

By the time she reached school, the sense of alignment had sharpened into something unmistakable.

People moved around her without collision. Schedules flowed. Interruptions smoothed themselves out before they became obstacles.

It was the kind of day people described as good.

Allison felt watched.

Not by eyes.

By expectation.

She stopped in the hallway between classes, standing perfectly still as students streamed past her. The flow bent around her without breaking, like water around a post.

No one bumped into her.

No one complained.

It was as if the space itself had learned her shape.

Her pulse quickened—not with fear, but with recognition.

This wasn't happening *to* her.

It was happening *for* her.

And she hadn't asked for it.

That afternoon, Evan didn't leave her side.

He didn't hover or ask questions. He just stayed close, a steady presence amid motion that no longer needed her input.

At the corner where they usually split, Allison stopped.

"I don't like this," she said quietly.

He waited.

"It feels like if I stop paying attention," she continued, "I'll wake up somewhere I didn't choose."

Evan's voice was gentle. "Then don't stop paying attention."

She looked at him, something like relief flickering through her chest.

"Will you—" She stopped herself and shook her head. "Never mind."

Evan hesitated, just for a moment, then reached for her hand.

He didn't lace his fingers through hers. He didn't squeeze. He just held on lightly, like he was giving her the option to pull away.

"I can walk you a little farther," he said.

She nodded. “Yeah.”

They turned together, continuing down the street.

The world flowed smoothly around them, cooperative and calm.

But for the first time, Allison understood what that calm was asking of her.

Not obedience.

Agreement.

And she wasn't ready to give it.

17.5 — Convergent Tolerance

The room had not changed.

That mattered.

The dimensions were the same. The surfaces remained neutral and unadorned. Even the light held steady, neither warmer nor colder than before. Continuity was important in spaces like this—not for comfort, but for comparison. Change introduced noise. Noise complicated judgment.

The projection resolved slowly, layer by layer, settling into a familiar lattice of paths and markers. Unlike prior reviews, nothing failed to render. No gaps appeared. No sequences stalled or collapsed.

Everything presented itself.

One of them leaned closer to the display. “This isn’t suppression.”

“No,” another replied after a moment. “It’s convergence.”

The woman at the table shifted her weight forward, studying the narrowing lines. She did not touch the surface this time. “Confirm scope.”

The lattice adjusted. Probabilities tightened. Where earlier projections had shown a spread of viable outcomes, this configuration formed a corridor—wide enough to allow variance, narrow enough to shape movement without force.

“She’s still declining escalation,” someone said quietly.

“Yes,” the woman replied. “But she isn’t resisting.”

A pause followed—not uncertainty, but calibration.

“Clarify.”

“The subject is choosing non-engagement,” she said.

“She is not disrupting flow. She remains within tolerable variance.”

The projection highlighted a series of minor adjustments: timing alignments, spatial smoothing, reduced friction. Each was small. Collectively, they created ease.

“All changes remain environmental,” another voice confirmed. “No direct pressure.”

“And consent?” someone asked.

The woman did not answer immediately. She watched the projection shift, waiting for it to settle.

“Implicit,” she said at last.

No one challenged the assessment.

“She’s observing,” the first voice said. “Recording. Modifying behavior.”

“Yes,” the woman agreed. “Which preserves agency.”

The projection overlaid a faint boundary—an ethical threshold, barely visible unless one knew where to look.

“As long as awareness persists,” the woman said,
“alignment remains non-coercive.”

“And if awareness lapses?”

“Then we reassess.”

The silence that followed carried anticipation, not
doubt.

“There’s increased stability,” someone noted.
“Secondary attachments appear to be anchoring.”

The woman’s expression remained neutral. “As
expected.”

“No isolation measures?”

“Unnecessary.”

The projection dimmed slightly, settling into a steady
state—neither advancing nor retreating.

“This was not the primary projected outcome,” one
voice observed.

“No,” the woman said. “But it falls within acceptable
parameters.”

She straightened. “Record the phase as *convergent
tolerance*.”

A brief hesitation. “Duration?”

Her gaze remained on the projection. “Indefinite.
Pending deviation.”

“And disclosure?”

She shook her head once. “Premature.”

The display faded, leaving the room unchanged.

What remained was not absence.

It was alignment—permitted to continue because it could still be mistaken for choice.

Chapter 25 — Consideration

Fourth period should have been forgettable.

The classroom was warm in that mid-afternoon way where the air felt a little too still, the kind of heat that made it hard to tell whether time was moving slowly or just quietly. Sunlight spilled through the high windows in pale bands, catching dust in the air. The teacher moved through the lesson at an even pace, voice steady, chalk squeaking softly against the board.

Allison followed along without effort. She always did. The material wasn't difficult, and she liked the predictability of it—the rhythm of copying notes, the comfort of knowing what was expected of her.

She had just written the last word of a sentence when the shadow crossed her desk.

The note appeared without ceremony, placed neatly on the corner as the teacher passed. The movement was practiced enough that it barely registered until the paper was already there.

Please see the main office after class.

That was all.

No name. No stamp. No explanation.

Allison stared at the note longer than necessary. Around her, pens moved. Someone coughed. A chair leg scraped quietly against the tile. The class continued, unbroken.

She folded the paper once and slid it into her notebook, the crease precise. Her pen resumed its steady motion, copying down notes she didn't need, each letter careful and even.

This, she thought, was new.

When the bell rang, the room shifted into motion all at once. Backpacks zipped. Chairs scraped. Voices rose and tangled in the familiar end-of-class rush.

Allison stayed seated.

She waited until the flow thinned, until the last few students drifted out, laughter echoing down the hall. The teacher lingered at the front of the room, stacking papers with unnecessary care.

When Allison finally stood and approached, the teacher looked up, hesitated, then smiled.

"I was asked to pass that along," she said, nodding toward Allison's notebook. "That's all."

"Okay," Allison said.

The teacher's expression flickered—something like uncertainty, quickly smoothed away. "You can head on," she added, already turning back to her desk.

There was no follow-up. No explanation. No question.

Allison walked out into the hallway, the sound of lockers slamming and voices rising around her. The note felt heavier now that it had purpose.

Lunch was almost normal.

People sat where they usually did. The same clusters formed, the same arguments about homework and weekend plans floated above the tables. The smell of food hung thick in the air, grease and disinfectant blending into something uniquely cafeteria-like.

Allison set her tray down but didn't eat.

She reached into her notebook, pulled out the folded paper, and smoothed it flat against the table. She stared at it, reading the same line over and over as if it might change.

Please see the main office after class.

She didn't notice Evan sit down beside her.

"You okay?" he asked quietly.

She blinked, then nodded once. "I think so."

She slid the paper back into her notebook and pushed her tray aside. Around them, conversation moved on uninterrupted.

Still, Allison noticed the small things.

The lunch monitor's gaze followed her a second longer than necessary before drifting away. A teacher she didn't recognize nodded as Allison passed. No one asked her to move when she paused too long near the drink station earlier; now, no one commented as she sat without eating.

Nothing was said.

That was what made it impossible to dismiss.

She pulled out her phone and typed quickly.

****Notes — Keep track****

- Note delivered, no explanation
- Attention feels coordinated
- Remember: noticing $\neq$ agreeing

She locked the phone and slipped it back into her pocket.

Time felt different when it was moving toward something.

The intercom crackled mid-lunch, flattening the noise in the room.

“Allison Crites, please come to the main office.”

The announcement wasn’t urgent. It wasn’t isolated. Just folded into the rhythm of the day.

Allison stood.

Evan was already on his feet.

“I’ll walk with you,” he said.

She nodded.

They moved through the cafeteria together, trays clattering, voices resuming behind them. The hallway beyond was quieter, the sounds of lunch muffled by closed doors.

At the office door, Evan stopped.

"I'll be here," he said.

Allison nodded again and went in.

The office smelled faintly of paper and cleaning solution. Phones rang softly behind the counter. A printer hummed somewhere out of sight.

The secretary smiled. "Have a seat. Someone will be with you shortly."

Allison sat.

Time stretched.

She watched the second hand on the clock complete slow, deliberate circles. A woman crossed the room carrying a stack of folders. A man leaned in to speak quietly to the secretary, his voice too low to hear.

No one looked at Allison for longer than a glance.

She waited.

The waiting was worse than the note.

Ms. Harding stepped out from one of the offices.

“Allison,” she said. “Have a seat.”

They moved into a small office. The door remained open behind them.

“I want to be clear,” Ms. Harding said as she settled into her chair. “You’re not in trouble.”

Allison nodded.

“This came across my desk,” Ms. Harding continued. “When that happens, we check in.”

Allison waited.

“I just wanted to make sure you knew that if anything starts to feel off—academically or otherwise—you can come talk to me,” Ms. Harding said. “That’s all this is.”

Decide.

“That’s all?” Allison asked.

“For now,” Ms. Harding said.

They stood. The meeting ended without ceremony.

The hallway outside the office felt brighter than it had on the way in.

Evan was still there.

He didn’t ask what happened.

He just reached for her hand.

She took it.

They stood there for a moment, fingers lightly intertwined, the school continuing around them as if nothing had shifted. Voices echoed from farther down the hall. A bell rang somewhere distant, muffled by walls.

Evan didn't ask what had happened.

He didn't need to.

"Do you want to go back?" he asked instead.

Allison looked toward the cafeteria doors. The sounds from inside drifted out—laughter, the scrape of chairs, the clatter of trays. Lunch was still happening.

"I guess," she said.

They walked together, unhurried.

The hallway felt longer on the way back, though they took the same route. Allison noticed how easily people stepped aside as they passed, how no one bumped into them, how movement adjusted without comment.

Inside the cafeteria, the noise swelled and then smoothed again, as if their absence had already been accounted for.

No one looked up when they returned.

That was the strangest part.

Jess was mid-story, hands moving as she talked. Kara laughed at something Allison missed. Someone slid into

the empty seat Allison had vacated earlier without asking, then slid back out just as easily when she approached.

“Oh—hey,” Kara said, shifting her tray to make room.
“You okay?”

“Yeah,” Allison said.

She sat.

Her tray was still where she’d left it, the food untouched and cooling. She picked up her fork, moved something around without eating, then set it back down again.

Conversation flowed on. The moment reabsorbed her without resistance, closing the gap she’d left behind as if it had never existed.

Evan stayed beside her longer than usual. Not hovering. Just close enough that she could feel the warmth of his arm when he leaned back.

Nothing had changed.

And that was the problem.

She had gone somewhere private. She had been reviewed. And now she was back, exactly where she’d been before.

No explanation offered.

No reaction required.

No mark left behind.

The world had opened, closed, and returned her without pause.

She glanced around the cafeteria again, looking for some sign that she'd missed something obvious.

There was nothing.

Evan leaned closer. "Want to head out early?"

Allison considered it.

"I think I want to finish lunch," she said.

"Okay," he said.

They stayed.

When the bell rang, everyone stood at once. Allison stood with them, shouldered her bag, moved with the crowd toward the doors.

Everything worked.

Too well.

As they stepped into the hallway, Allison felt the weight of the day settle—not heavy, not sharp, just present.

She reached for Evan's hand again as they walked.

He took it.

Around them, the school moved on, orderly and intact.

And Allison walked back into it, knowing that whatever had noticed her hadn't needed to keep her.

It had already learned where she fit.

Chapter 25 — Narrowing

The change showed up as an email.

Allison almost deleted it.

It sat in her inbox between a reminder about library books and a notification from a club she didn't remember joining. The subject line was so neutral it barely registered.

****Schedule Update****

She opened it anyway.

The message was brief. Courteous. Informational.

A course section adjusted. An elective consolidated. A room change to improve flow. The language was clean and optimistic, every sentence polished until nothing caught. Nothing had been removed. Nothing canceled. No choices presented.

Her schedule still worked.

That was what unsettled her.

She read it again, slower this time, not for content but for intent. The words slid past without resistance, each one designed to reassure without explaining anything at all. The email ended with a pleasant sign-off and a line about minimizing disruption.

She didn't delete it.

She didn't archive it either.

She locked her phone and stood, already late in a way that didn't register on the clock.

By second period, the hallway felt tuned.

Not quieter. Not louder. Just arranged.

She reached her classroom just as the bell rang, the door swinging shut behind her with gentle finality. Inside, the desks had been shifted—only slightly. Rows closer together. Aisles narrowed by inches that shouldn't have mattered.

They did.

Allison hesitated, just long enough to notice that the seat she usually chose wasn't open. She took another without thinking about why that felt like a decision.

The teacher smiled and began without comment.

During the lesson, Allison tried to lean back in her chair the way she always did. Her elbow brushed the desk behind her. She adjusted, then adjusted again, then sat still.

When the bell rang, the room emptied with unusual precision. Students moved in coordinated currents, paths aligning without conversation or confusion.

Allison followed.

Lunch didn't break the pattern.

If anything, it confirmed it.

The table filled quickly. Kara waved her over without pausing her story. Jess shifted her tray aside before Allison asked. Evan arrived a moment later and sat like the space had been held.

“You see the schedule thing?” Kara asked casually, already past concern.

Allison paused, long enough to feel the delay. “What thing?”

“The update,” Kara said. “They merged our chem sections. It’s actually better. Less chaos.”

Jess nodded. “Yeah. Calmer.”

Better.

Calmer.

Allison nodded with them, her fork hovering above her tray.

“Streamlined,” Kara added, approving.

The word settled somewhere uncomfortable.

Allison reached into her bag and pulled out her phone, opening the email again beneath the table. She scanned it once more, then again, trying to locate the moment where she could have said no.

There wasn’t one.

Nothing had been taken.

Everything had been placed.

She set the phone down and stared at her food without eating.

Evan glanced at her, then deliberately looked away.

That restraint felt heavier than attention.

By the time lunch ended, the day had already tightened.

Classes turned over with mechanical accuracy. Doors opened as she reached them. Teachers paused just long enough for questions no one asked.

Once, she stopped near a water fountain she didn't need, pretending to check her phone. The line curved around her without complaint. When she stepped back in, the timing corrected itself seamlessly.

She tried again near a classroom doorway, pausing just short of entering. Someone behind her waited without irritation. Someone ahead adjusted without comment.

When she moved, everything resumed.

She arrived everywhere exactly when she was expected.

She wondered, briefly, what would happen if she didn't.

The thought didn't land anywhere solid.

After school, she didn't go home.

Not because she decided not to — because stopping felt harder than continuing.

She walked, letting the longer route take her without choosing it. The neighborhood felt suspended, the air heavy with the promise of rain that never arrived.

At the creek, she stopped.

This was where things usually loosened. Where time stretched. Where standing still felt allowed.

She leaned against the railing and waited.

Nothing pushed.

Nothing resisted.

The quiet felt prepared, like it had been waiting for her too.

She pulled out her phone.

****Notes — Don't ignore this****

- Changes framed as improvements
- Nothing blocked — just redirected
- No clear moment to refuse
- Avoidance used to be an option

She stared at the new line until the screen dimmed.

No clear moment to refuse.

She locked the phone, her chest tight in a way she couldn't fully explain.

Evan joined her without announcement, stopping close enough that she didn't have to turn to know he was there.

"I figured you'd be here," he said.

"They changed things," she said.

He nodded. "Yeah."

"It all still works," she said. "I can do everything I was doing before."

"But you have to keep doing it," he said quietly.

The words landed harder than she expected.

She nodded. "If I stop moving, I fall behind. Not because I'm late. Because everything else keeps going."

He leaned against the railing beside her, solid, steady.

"Do you want to push back?" he asked.

She considered the question carefully.

"I don't know where I'd put my hands," she said.

"There's nothing to grab."

They stood together as the light shifted, clouds thickening overhead without breaking.

For the first time, Allison understood what had changed.

She hadn't lost her freedom.

She'd lost the space around it.

Chapter 25 — Friction

Allison tried to make a different choice on purpose.

It wasn't dramatic. It wasn't brave. It was small enough that no one would have noticed if it hadn't mattered.

Between second and third period, she didn't take the hallway she always took.

She turned left instead of right, cutting past the science wing, telling herself she just wanted a quieter route. A little space. A moment where the day didn't already feel arranged.

The corridor was empty in the way hallways usually weren't. Lights buzzed overhead, steady and indifferent. The floor shone with fresh wax, reflecting her shoes back at her in pale fragments.

She slowed.

She waited for something to correct her.

Nothing did.

Her footsteps sounded too loud. She adjusted her pace, then slowed again, testing whether hesitation would register as anything other than delay.

It didn't.

She reached the intersection at the end of the hall and stopped.

There should have been noise here. Students spilling in from the other wing. Someone blocking the corner. A

reason to merge back into the flow.

Instead, there was a door.

It wasn't new. It wasn't hidden. It wasn't marked in a way that suggested urgency.

A printed sign was taped to the glass:

****STUDENT SERVICES****

The paper was slightly crooked. The tape had yellowed at the edges, as if it had been replaced more than once without anyone bothering to straighten it.

Allison stared at it, trying to remember if she'd ever noticed it before.

She couldn't.

Her schedule buzzed in her pocket.

She ignored it.

After a moment that stretched longer than it should have, she pushed the door open.

The room inside was smaller than the main office. Quiet in a way that felt intentional rather than empty.

Chairs lined one wall, mismatched but clean. A desk sat beneath a bulletin board layered with flyers about deadlines and planning and asking for help early. Nothing urgent. Nothing specific.

Ms. Harding sat behind the desk, typing.

She didn't look rushed. She didn't look surprised.

She simply looked up when the door opened.

"Yes?" she said.

Allison stopped just inside the threshold. "I—I think I took the wrong hallway."

Ms. Harding glanced at the clock on the wall, then back at Allison. Her expression didn't change.

"That's okay," she said. "You can come in or head on. Either way."

The choice felt real for exactly half a second.

"I'm going to be late," Allison said.

Ms. Harding turned her monitor slightly, eyes flicking across the screen. Something updated with a soft chime Allison hadn't noticed before.

"You're marked present," Ms. Harding said, without emphasis.

Allison's stomach dropped. "I didn't—"

"It updates automatically," Ms. Harding said. Not explanatory. Just factual.

The sentence closed the space where a question might have lived.

Allison looked around the room again, searching for a reason she was here. There wasn't one. Nothing in the room pointed to her. Nothing suggested intention.

“I didn’t mean to come here,” she said, quieter this time.

Ms. Harding nodded once, already looking back at her screen. “That happens.”

The phrase landed with more weight than it should have.

After a moment, Ms. Harding stood. She didn’t step toward Allison. She didn’t gesture her farther inside. She didn’t block the door.

“Is there anything you needed while you’re here?” she asked.

The question felt procedural. Like something she’d asked many times already that day.

“No,” Allison said quickly.

Ms. Harding nodded. “Okay.”

She tapped something into the computer. A printer hummed softly behind the desk, then stopped. The sound was small but definitive.

“All set,” Ms. Harding said.

Allison waited.

Nothing else happened.

“You can head to class,” Ms. Harding said.

Allison turned and left.

The door closed behind her with a quiet click that felt louder than it should have.

The hallway outside had filled while she was inside.

Students moved past in steady streams, conversations resuming mid-sentence as if nothing had paused. Someone brushed her shoulder lightly and murmured an apology without slowing.

Allison moved with them.

She reached her classroom before the bell finished ringing.

Her teacher glanced up, smiled, and continued the lesson without comment.

Allison sat down, hands shaking just enough that she pressed them flat against her thighs to steady them.

She had taken the wrong hallway.

She had opened the wrong door.

And still, she had arrived exactly where she was expected.

At lunch, she didn't pull out her phone.

Not the email.

Not the calendar.

Not anything that might make the day notice her noticing it.

She focused on eating, on nodding at the right moments, on keeping her movements ordinary. She laughed when someone else laughed. She answered questions with enough detail to sound present.

Evan sat beside her, quieter than usual.

“You went the other way,” he said softly, not looking at her.

Allison’s fork paused. “Yeah.”

“And?”

She swallowed. “It didn’t matter.”

Evan turned then, his expression serious. “What do you mean?”

“I mean it was like the day already had room for it,” she said. “Like there wasn’t a wrong direction. Just... other ways in.”

Evan frowned slightly. “Did someone talk to you?”

“Not really,” Allison said. The words felt thin even as she said them. “There was a door. And a desk. And then it was done.”

“That’s it?”

“That was enough,” she said.

Evan was quiet for a long moment.

“That’s not friction,” he said finally. “That’s absorption.”

The word settled somewhere cold.

After school, Allison went straight home.

Not because she wanted to. Because she didn’t want to find out what else might be waiting.

The house was quiet when she stepped inside, familiar in a way that almost hurt. She dropped her bag by the door and stood there for a moment longer than necessary, listening.

Nothing followed her in.

Her phone buzzed.

A calendar notification sat at the top of the screen.

****Check-in — 8:10 AM****

No location listed.

No sender named.

No explanation offered.

It was scheduled for the next morning.

Allison stared at it, waiting for the option to dismiss it to feel solid under her thumb.

It didn’t.

She opened her notes app.

****Notes — This is different****

- Deviating doesn't create delay
- Redirection happens before I notice
- No one stops me — they adjust

She saved the note.

She left the calendar event where it was.

Not because she agreed.

Because she still couldn't find the place where refusal would land.

Chapter 21 — The Omission

Allison noticed it first in the way people kept saying when.

When it reaches us.

When it hits here.

When this passes.

No one said if.

She heard it at school, teachers lowering their voices in the hallways, sentences thinning out as she approached. She heard it at the grocery store, where a conversation

about meat prices stopped entirely when she stepped into the aisle. She heard it at the library, where Mrs. Calder smiled too carefully and said, “Hopefully it skips us,” and then looked like she’d said something she hadn’t meant to say out loud.

It wasn’t panic.

It was expectation.

The kind that hummed, low and constant, like the sound of a refrigerator in the middle of the night—easy to ignore until you couldn’t.

By the time Allison walked to Evan’s house, she felt like the town was leaning forward, waiting to see what would happen next. The sky was pale and flat, the air too still. It felt like the day had stalled.

The television was on when she stepped inside.

Not loud. Not centered. Just there.

A reporter stood in a muddy field, her boots sunk into the ground. Behind her, cattle shifted and stamped, their movements restless in a way Allison had never really noticed before. The text at the bottom of the screen scrolled steadily, unemotional.

Allison slowed.

Then stopped.

Maps followed. Bright blocks of color spreading outward. Town names appeared one after another—places close enough that she recognized them

instantly, places she'd been before.

Her eyes moved with the shapes.

"That's—" she started, then fell quiet.

Mara reached for the remote and lowered the volume.

Not off. Just lower.

Jonah glanced at the screen once, then away, like he'd already confirmed something for himself.

Evan came down the stairs, taking the last step too fast. He followed Allison's gaze to the television.

"What's going on?" he asked.

"They're showing everywhere around us," Allison said.

"But not—"

"Yes," Mara said, turning toward her.

Just that.

Allison waited.

Mara didn't continue.

The reporter gestured at the map again, the same colored regions pulsing faintly as the camera zoomed in and out.

Still not theirs.

"That seems... wrong," Allison said slowly. "Right?"

Jonah set a glass down on the counter. It made a soft sound, but in the quiet it felt loud. "News maps aren't

always precise.”

“But they’re naming towns,” Allison said. “And those are right next to us.”

“They’re focusing on confirmed cases,” Mara said. “Coverage tends to lag behind reality.”

That sounded like information.

It didn’t settle anything.

“So we could still be next,” Allison said.

Mara’s pause was brief. Almost invisible. “It’s possible.”

“And nobody’s saying anything?” Evan asked.

“They don’t always,” Jonah said. “Not until they have to.”

That wasn’t reassuring either.

The map stayed on the screen longer than Allison expected. She kept waiting for their town to appear, like a late-arriving label. It didn’t.

When the segment finally ended, Mara muted the television completely, leaving the screen flickering in silence.

Conversation picked back up, but it felt... bent. Like it was being routed around something fragile. Every time Allison tried to circle back toward the news—by asking about school, or farms, or why people were acting weird—it slid away from her.

They weren't refusing to talk.

They were refusing to stay there.

When Allison stood to leave, Evan stood too, immediately. No hesitation.

Mara hugged her—warm, careful, normal.

“Take care,” she said.

Outside, the quiet felt heavier than before, like the air had thickened while they were inside.

They walked half a block before Allison spoke.

“They skipped us,” she said again, like saying it twice might make it make sense.

“Yeah,” Evan said.

“That doesn't happen.”

“No.”

She kicked at a loose stone, sending it skittering ahead of them. “My dad said once that stuff like that always spreads. Especially if it's feed or water or whatever. You can't just... stop it.”

“Mine said the same thing,” Evan said. “He said if one place gets hit, everyone connected to it eventually does.”

“So either they're wrong,” Allison said, “or something interrupted it.”

“Or the map's wrong,” Evan offered.

“Then why are your parents acting like it’s right?”

He didn’t answer immediately.

“Okay,” he said finally. “Yeah. That part’s weird.”

They walked a little farther.

“And they weren’t surprised,” Allison added. “Not really.”

“No.”

“They looked like they were... checking something.”

Evan frowned. “Checking what?”

“I don’t know,” she said. “Like they were waiting to see if the TV would say something specific.”

They reached her street. Evan slowed, then matched her pace instead of stopping.

“Do you think it’ll still happen?” she asked.

“I don’t know,” he said. “But everyone’s acting like it already did. Like it already... resolved.”

“That’s not how things work,” Allison said.

“No,” Evan agreed. “It’s not.”

At her house, Evan stopped at the end of the driveway. He didn’t offer a theory. He didn’t try to make it better.

He just stayed.

Inside, the kitchen lights were on. Her mom stood at the counter with her phone in her hand. Her dad sat at the

table, the television muted in front of him.

The same map was frozen on the screen.

“Oh,” her mom said. “You’ve seen this, right?”

“All around us,” Allison said. “But not here.”

Her dad nodded. “That’s what it looks like.”

“Is that normal?” Allison asked.

Her parents exchanged a glance—not sharp, not coordinated. Just worried.

“Sometimes things don’t go the way people expect,” her mom said.

The words felt thinner now.

“But they’re testing feed,” Allison said. “And water. And—”

“We don’t have all the details yet,” her dad said gently. “News gets ahead of itself.”

“So we’re just... fine?” Allison asked.

“For now,” her mom said. “Looks that way.”

No one said why.

Later, in bed, Allison opened her Notes app.

She stared at the blank screen for a long time before typing.

- Everyone expected it to happen here.

- It happened everywhere else.
- The map skipped us.
- Adults noticed.
- Nobody explained.
- That should feel lucky.

She paused.

Deleted the last line.

Typed instead:

- It doesn't feel lucky.

She stared at the words until the screen dimmed.

Somewhere nearby, cattle were sick. Somewhere closer, they weren't.

The world had made room for that difference.

She still didn't know how.

But now she knew she wasn't the only one who noticed.

Chapter 22 — Proximity

The first thing Allison noticed was how often people asked her where she was going.

Not abruptly. Not like an interrogation.

Just small questions, slipped into conversation the way people asked about the weather or dinner plans. Casual

enough that answering felt normal. Specific enough that she noticed when it happened again.

Mrs. Calder did it at the library, pausing mid-stamp and looking up with a polite smile.

“Heading somewhere specific, Allison?”

“Home,” Allison said.

Mrs. Calder nodded, the tension leaving her shoulders so quickly Allison almost missed it.

“All right, then.”

She went back to her work immediately, the question resolved as neatly as if Allison had handed her a receipt.

That was the part Allison couldn’t shake.

Not the question.

The relief.

Allison told herself it was nothing. People asked questions all the time.

It was only later that she realized it had happened twice.

Coach Ramirez did something similar after practice. He stood with his clipboard tucked against his arm, eyes flicking between Allison and the path that led away from the field.

“You heading out?” he asked.

“Yeah.”

“Usual way?”

“I think so.”

He hesitated — not long, but long enough to register — then smiled.

“Might want to take the long way today. Less foot traffic.”

Allison waited.

Coach Ramirez didn’t elaborate.

She almost asked why. Almost didn’t.

In the end, she nodded and turned the way he’d suggested.

It wasn’t until she was halfway home that the realization landed: the suggestion hadn’t existed until after she’d answered. He hadn’t decided until she named a direction.

By the time she reached school the next day, Allison was already paying closer attention than usual.

At first, everything looked the same. Same lockers. Same announcements. Same dull hum of voices. But movement felt different, like the building was responding to where she was instead of the other way around.

A hallway she used every day grew crowded just as she reached it. A classroom door closed at the exact wrong moment, a teacher stepping out with an apologetic expression.

“Sorry,” the teacher said lightly. “You’ll want to go around today.”

“Why?” Allison asked.

The teacher paused, eyes flicking briefly past Allison’s shoulder before returning.

“Just easier.”

Allison stood there a moment longer than necessary. The teacher waited with her, smiling, patient. Not forcing. Just present.

Allison turned.

Behind her, the hallway opened again almost immediately.

It didn’t feel like being stopped.

It felt like being guided.

The feeling followed her through the morning, collecting small moments she couldn’t quite set down.

By lunchtime, the hum in her chest was steady enough that she pulled out her phone without thinking and opened her Notes app.

- People keep asking where I’m going.
- They relax after I answer.
- Things change after I decide.

She locked her phone the moment Evan sat down across from her, the words still sitting heavy in her head.

“You’ve got that look,” he said.

“What look?”

“The one where you’re trying to figure out if something’s real or if you’re just tired.”

“I’m not tired.”

“Uh-huh.”

“They’re not stopping me,” she said instead. “They’re just moving things once I’m already headed somewhere.”

“That’s worse,” Evan said after a moment.

She glanced up at him.

“Why?”

“Because it means they’re paying attention.”

She hadn’t said that out loud yet.

They left lunch together. Allison chose the shorter route toward the science wing on purpose, curious whether the feeling would follow.

It did.

A staff member stepped into the corridor ahead of them, clipboard tucked against her chest.

“Hallway’s closed for cleaning,” she said cheerfully.

Allison didn’t turn this time. She looked past the woman at the still-open corridor beyond.

“For how long?” Allison asked.

The woman glanced down at her clipboard, then back up.

“Not long. You’ll want to go around for now.”

Evan shifted beside her.

“Why?”

The woman smiled — still pleasant, still calm — but something tightened around her eyes.

“It’s just easier.”

Allison turned.

As soon as she did, the woman stepped aside and the hallway behind them opened again, students passing through like nothing had happened.

Evan stopped walking.

“Allison,” he said quietly.

“I know.”

Neither of them said anything else, but the silence felt charged, watching.

This time, Allison didn’t wait for the feeling to find her.

Later that afternoon, she walked toward the feed store.

She’d barely committed to the direction when she saw the sign.

TEMPORARILY CLOSED

CHECK BACK SOON

It hadn't been there that morning.

She stopped, pulse ticking faster than it should have.
The windows were dark. No movement inside.

A truck rolled past slowly. The driver glanced at her,
then forward again.

Allison turned around.

The tension followed her home, settling into the quiet
spaces between questions.

Her mom asked how her day had been.

Her dad asked if she wanted help with homework.

Both questions were gentle. Both carried a carefulness
Allison couldn't quite place, like they were checking
something without saying what.

"Maybe later," Allison said.

Her dad nodded easily.

"All right."

That seemed to settle them.

Later — after dinner, after homework she mostly
finished on her own, after the house went quiet —
Allison replayed the day instead of moving past it.

The questions.

The pauses.

The way things shifted once she answered.

She woke up still thinking about it.

The feeling followed her through the morning routine, through first period and second, through a day that looked ordinary and didn't feel like it. Nothing obvious happened. Nothing needed to.

By the time the final bell rang, the hum in her chest hadn't faded.

The next afternoon, Evan waited by the bike racks instead of their usual spot.

"They moved robotics," Evan said as soon as she reached him.

His voice was casual, but he didn't look at her right away. He kept glancing past the bike racks, toward the building.

"Again?" Allison asked.

"Earlier," he said. "Like... earlier today." He hesitated, then added, "They never do that."

"How early?"

He checked his phone again.

"Ten minutes ago. Maybe more."

"That's not early," Allison said. "That's already happening."

Evan let out a short breath.

“Yeah.”

They started walking.

“They’re probably already assigning roles,” he said, not quite to her.

“All the good ones,” Allison said before she could stop herself.

He gave a short laugh.

“Yeah. Those.”

They walked another few steps.

“I could still catch part of it,” he said.

“You could,” she agreed.

He didn’t speed up.

His phone buzzed again. This time he turned the screen away from her.

“They’re asking where I am,” he said quietly.

Allison stopped.

Evan took one more step before realizing she wasn’t beside him anymore.

“You don’t have to stay,” she said.

“I know,” he said.

He stayed anyway.

They walked the rest of the way slowly. Evan checked his phone twice, thumb hovering like he might type something. He never did.

At the end of her driveway, he stopped.

“You’re sure?” Allison asked.

“Yeah,” he said. “I’ll catch up later.”

Later sounded thin.

He waited until she unlocked the door anyway.

Evan didn’t text her that night.

Not to say he’d made it.

Not to complain.

Not to explain.

The next morning at school, he was quieter than usual. When someone mentioned robotics at lunch, he didn’t join in. He just nodded, once, and looked away.

That was how Allison knew he’d missed more than a meeting.

The weight of the day stayed with her longer than usual.

That night, Allison lay on her bed and stared at the ceiling.

The crack was still there.

Same length. Same branching. Same pale certainty.

She followed it with her eyes, cataloging it the way she always did.

Not urgent.

Not dangerous.

Stable.

The ceiling hadn't changed.

Everything else felt like it was adjusting around where she stood.

And sometimes, around who stood with her.

Chapter 23 — Standing

At lunch, Evan sat across from Allison and stared at his tray without touching it.

She noticed because he usually didn't do that. Evan usually ate first and talked at the same time, like silence was something to be avoided rather than filled.

"You're not eating," she said.

"I will," he said, still looking down.

She waited.

After a moment, he picked up his fork, shifted a few things around, then set it back down again. The food hadn't moved enough to matter.

"You okay?" she asked.

“Yeah.” He hesitated, then added, quieter, “Do you ever feel like you missed something and everyone else just... kept going?”

The question didn’t sound hypothetical.

She thought of the hallway opening behind her. The sign that hadn’t been there that morning. The way answers seemed to resolve things.

“Yes,” she said.

Evan looked up at her then, relief crossing his face so quickly it startled her. Like he’d been bracing for a different answer.

They didn’t talk about robotics. Evan didn’t bring it up. Allison didn’t ask. It sat between them anyway, unnamed but present, like a chair someone had pulled out and left empty.

When Evan stood to throw his trash away, Allison watched him go, half-expecting him to come back and say something when he returned.

He didn’t.

Someone slid into his seat without looking.

Allison noticed immediately. Evan noticed too — she could tell by the way his shoulders tightened when he glanced over — but he kept moving, the moment passing without comment.

That bothered her more than if he’d said something.

The rest of lunch unraveled oddly after that. Conversations overlapped without settling. Someone leaned across the table to ask Allison a question and didn't even look at Evan while waiting for a response. Another voice cut in before he could finish a sentence.

She hadn't realized how often that didn't happen until it did.

After school, Allison lingered by her locker longer than necessary, pretending to reorganize her bag. Evan waited nearby, scrolling through his phone without actually reading anything.

"Do you want to walk?" she asked.

"Yeah," he said immediately.

Too immediately.

They stepped outside together, the late afternoon sun flattening shadows across the steps. Students poured past them in uneven waves, conversations breaking apart and reforming as people peeled off in different directions.

Halfway down the steps, a teacher called Evan's name.

"Evan."

He turned.

Mr. Kline stood by the doors, arms crossed loosely, posture relaxed in a way that wasn't casual.

"Missed you yesterday," he said.

“Yeah,” Evan said. “I—”

“No worries,” Mr. Kline said, cutting in gently. “Just wanted to make sure everything’s good.”

“Everything’s good,” Evan said.

Mr. Kline nodded. His eyes flicked briefly to Allison, then back to Evan.

“We’ll catch up,” he said.

He went back inside.

Evan didn’t move right away.

He stood there like he was deciding whether the conversation was actually over.

“That was about robotics,” he said finally.

Allison nodded.

“They didn’t say anything,” he added. “They don’t have to.”

They started walking again, but Evan kept glancing back toward the doors like he expected someone else to come out. No one did.

A few blocks later, his phone buzzed.

He checked it. His mouth tightened.

“What?” Allison asked.

“Nothing,” he said automatically. Then he frowned at the screen again. “That’s... not right.”

She waited.

“They moved the sign-up,” he said. “For the next round.”

He slowed, then stopped altogether, the sidewalk suddenly too narrow.

“They filled most of it,” he added. “Already.”

“That was fast,” Allison said.

“Yeah.”

He stared at the phone for another second, then locked it, like that would keep the information from settling.

“I didn’t even know it was open,” he said.

Allison thought about how people asked her where she was going. How answers seemed to calm things down.

“Did anyone tell you?” she asked.

He shook his head. “No. They just... assumed.”

Assumed what stayed between them, unspoken.

They walked the rest of the way in a quieter rhythm, steps falling into sync without either of them trying. When they reached the corner near her street, Evan slowed.

“You don’t have to walk me all the way,” Allison said.

“I know.”

He kept going anyway.

At her driveway, Evan stopped and looked back toward the street like he was checking for something that hadn't followed them.

"Does it bother you?" Allison asked.

He frowned. "That's not fair."

She almost apologized.

Then he exhaled. "No," he said. "But I don't like how easy it was."

"How easy what was?"

"How fast it happened," he said. "Like I was there one day and... not, the next."

That sounded familiar in a way Allison didn't like.

Inside, her parents were watching television. The volume was low. A weather map glowed faintly on the screen.

Allison didn't stop to look.

Later that night, she opened her Notes app.

She typed a line, then erased it.

Typed another.

- Evan missed something.

Deleted.

She tried again.

- Evan wasn't where he was supposed to be.

That didn't feel right either.

She erased it and stared at the blank screen until her eyes burned.

Finally, she typed:

- Evan stood still.
- People noticed.
- No one asked why.

She read it twice.

Then added:

- Standing still counts as choosing.

She locked her phone and set it face-down on the nightstand.

Somewhere else — beyond her sight, beyond the edges of the town — decisions were still being made.

She didn't know who was making them.

She only knew they were starting to leave marks.

Interlude 23.5 — Boundary Conditions

The first review happened before the storm was supposed to arrive.

That part was routine.

The models were clear, the confidence margins narrow enough to justify early action. Alert thresholds had been met well in advance. Records reflected the certainty cleanly: preparation approved, escalation appropriate, no discretionary override required.

The region was flagged as high impact.

Alders Creek sat well within the boundary.

After the storm window closed, the review happened again.

This time it moved more slowly.

The initial assumption was delay. That was standard. Systems were allowed time to reconcile projected outcomes with incoming data. Variance occurred. Timing slipped. No one was concerned yet.

When the delay extended past acceptable bounds, verification was rerun.

The result did not change.

There was no registered impact.

Not reduced.

Not redirected.

Absent.

“Check the instruments,” someone said, already scrolling through the logs.

They did.

Sensor data was intact. Redundancy held. No outages were recorded. No feeds showed corruption or interruption. The storm structure appeared consistently before and after the expected window, maintaining both shape and intensity.

It had simply not expressed there.

They widened the view.

Surrounding zones showed the expected markers: pressure drops, wind signatures, infrastructure stress. Cleanup flags populated automatically. Response queues filled and were acknowledged in sequence.

Alders Creek returned clean.

Someone paused over the boundary overlay.

“That can’t be right,” they said—not sharply, not with urgency. Just neutrally.

“It’s right,” another replied. “It’s just not reasonable.”

They ran it again anyway.

The boundary held.

A note was added to the record: verify exclusion zone consistency.

A second dataset was pulled. Not weather-related.

Agricultural monitoring. Supply integrity. Distribution outcomes.

The comparison finished loading, and someone leaned closer to the screen.

“Did we ever resolve this one?” they asked.

The earlier anomaly surfaced without emphasis. Feed contamination had been projected. Exposure expected. Adjacent areas flagged and confirmed.

Alders Creek again returned null.

The silence that followed wasn’t alarmed.

It was thoughtful.

Two independent predictive domains.

Two confirmed expectations.

One shared absence.

Someone tapped the desk once, lightly.

“That’s not variance,” they said.

“No,” another agreed. “Variance averages out.”

The overlay was adjusted again. The focus tightened. The exclusion zone remained precise, unchanged by scale or angle.

Nothing missing.

Nothing extra.

Nothing wrong with the inputs.

The outputs were the problem.

A third review was scheduled, then quietly canceled.

There was no need.

A classification note was opened.

The language used was careful.

Not failure.

Not interference.

Not cause.

Handling.

“Until further notice,” someone said, “we shouldn’t rely on projection alone.”

A pause followed.

“And?” someone prompted.

“And we shouldn’t correct for it,” the first replied. “Not yet.”

No one objected.

A procedural adjustment followed. It wasn’t large or dramatic. Boundaries tightened slightly. Assumptions narrowed. Downstream dependencies were flagged for caution rather than action.

Alders Creek was no longer treated as neutral.

The record reflected that without emphasis.

Before the file was closed, a final line was added beneath the others. It wasn’t highlighted or tagged. It didn’t draw attention to itself.

It simply existed.

Deviation confirmed. Outcome absent. Pattern consistent.

The entry was accepted.

Elsewhere, sirens faded without ever sounding.

Chapter 24 — Containment

The sky had been wrong since morning.

Not stormy. Not dramatic. Just heavy—gray pressed low and still, like the day had been placed under a lid.

School let out early.

There wasn't the usual relief about it, no sudden chatter about free hours or unexpected time. Teachers moved with a practiced calm that made the hallways feel smaller. Instructions were given the way you gave instructions when you didn't want questions: clear, gentle, final.

"Everyone head straight to buses."

"Don't linger."

"Go home."

Allison watched people obey without noticing they were obeying.

It wasn't fear. It was something quieter—like the town had already agreed on what the day was going to be, and the only thing left was to follow the route.

At the edge of the building, Evan found her. Not with a wave across the crowd. Not with his normal easy grin. He just stepped into her path at the right moment, like he'd been timed to it.

"You okay?" he asked.

"I'm fine," Allison said, because that was what you said on early dismissal days.

Evan looked toward the parking lot, then toward the office doors. His attention kept pulling away from her and coming back, like he was trying to keep two things in view at once.

"They're acting like it's already here," he said.

"It's not," Allison said.

He nodded, once, sharp. "Yeah."

They walked toward the buses. The air outside felt thick and still, like it was holding its breath. Somewhere far away, a siren started and then cut off again. Not close enough to frighten. Not far enough to ignore.

Evan slowed at the curb.

"Do you want me to—" he started.

"What?" Allison asked.

He stopped, rubbed the back of his neck. "Nothing. Sorry."

Allison waited, but he didn't finish the sentence.

The bus doors folded shut between them a minute later.

By the time Allison got home, the television was already on.

Not loud. Not urgent. Just there, as if it had been turned on hours ago and no one had thought to turn it off.

Her mom had moved a chair closer to the window. Her dad stood by the counter with his phone in his hand, thumb hovering over the screen like he was refreshing something he didn't want to read.

"They're saying it'll pass through by mid-afternoon," her mom said, not looking at Allison. "We might lose power."

"Okay," Allison said.

Her mom nodded like that was what she needed.

Her dad set his phone face-down on the counter, a gesture that felt deliberate in a way Allison couldn't place. Like if he didn't look, the information couldn't get in.

Allison drifted toward the front window. The light outside had a washed-out quality, like someone had turned down the color in the world. Trees barely moved. The air looked thick, as if it had weight.

Somewhere, another siren sounded, longer this time.

Allison held her breath without meaning to.

It stopped.

Her mom began to prepare without saying she was preparing. Candles appeared on the table. A flashlight

got placed next to the sink. A bowl of water was set out for no reason Allison could name.

Emily drifted through the living room with her headphones half on, half off, pausing near the window like she was deciding whether to be interested.

“Are we actually supposed to worry?” she asked.

Their mom didn’t turn around. “Just be ready.”

Emily made a face, shrugged, and went back upstairs, the question already forgotten.

Her dad checked the porch once, then again, then came back inside and closed the door more carefully than usual.

The television showed a radar map—bands of color curling and shifting. Reds and yellows in motion. A line of warnings drawn across the screen like a boundary.

Alders Creek sat under a bright shape that looked too neat.

Allison watched the image without understanding it. The storm mass shifted closer, then seemed to hesitate, as if it had to decide what to do.

Her mom spoke again, softly, like she didn’t want to disturb the day.

“This doesn’t make sense,” she said.

Allison turned to her. “What doesn’t?”

Her mom's eyes stayed on the screen. "They were so sure."

Her dad didn't answer.

The waiting stretched.

For a while, all the sounds in the house seemed too loud—the refrigerator cycling, the tick of the kitchen clock, the rustle of a curtain when someone walked past it.

Outside, the sky dimmed. Not quickly, not dramatically—just gradually, as if the afternoon had been replaced with an older kind of light. A gust of wind lifted the leaves on the street once, sent them skittering, then stopped.

Allison watched the trees, expecting them to move again.

They didn't.

A siren sounded in the distance—long, steady, then fading.

Allison's stomach tightened.

Her mom's hand went to her chest, fingers pressed lightly over her shirt as if that would steady something inside.

Her dad stood up.

He went to the back door and opened it just a crack, peering out into the yard as though he expected to see the storm standing there waiting.

He closed it again and didn't say what he saw.

Hours passed in pieces.

Her mom checked the television, then the window, then her phone, then the television again. Her dad sat down and stood up and sat down again. Allison stayed near the window, because it felt like the only honest place to be.

The storm never arrived.

The rain never came.

There was no moment where it "passed." No sudden clearing. No satisfying shift from danger to relief.

Just... nothing. The day loosened slowly, like a fist unclenching.

By late afternoon, the sky lifted a shade lighter. The air cooled. The street stayed dry.

The house stayed bright.

Her mom let out a breath, long and careful, like she'd been holding it for hours and didn't want anyone to notice.

No one said, We're safe.

No one said, We got lucky.

Dinner happened because dinner happened. The motions were normal—plates, forks, chairs—but conversation kept stalling like it couldn't find traction.

Her parents asked questions that didn't seem to require answers.

"Did you finish your homework?"

"Do you want more water?"

"Do you need anything for tomorrow?"

Allison answered anyway.

Everything felt decided in advance.

After dinner, the news shifted tone. The weather map disappeared. Footage from nearby towns filled the screen—downed branches, traffic lights out, streets littered with debris. A reporter stood in front of a building with a broken window, voice steady, describing outages and cleanup.

Alders Creek wasn't mentioned.

Emily sat cross-legged on the floor with her phone, scrolling through photos someone had posted from a town Allison recognized.

"They lost power for, like, six hours," Emily said.

No one answered.

Emily glanced up, frowned slightly, then went back to her screen.

Allison waited for Alders Creek to appear like you waited for your name to be called in a room that was calling everyone else.

It didn't happen.

Her mom turned the volume down further, as if the words were sharp.

Her dad watched the footage with the same stillness he'd had all day.

Later, in her room, her phone buzzed.

Evan.

"Did you hear about the storm stuff?"

Allison stared at the message longer than necessary.

"Yeah. It didn't happen."

The typing bubble appeared, vanished.

"It happened everywhere else."

"My aunt's place lost power."

"Are you okay?"

A pause.

"Yeah."

"It's just weird."

Another message came through.

"They want me to come in tomorrow. Not school. Robotics."

Allison sat up straighter.

"Why?"

The typing bubble appeared, stayed, vanished.

“They said it’s an opportunity.”

“What kind?”

“Regional program. Off-site.”

“They already set it up.”

Already.

“Did you sign up?”

“No.”

The bubble appeared again.

“They asked my parents.”

“Not me.”

Allison’s stomach tightened.

“What did your parents say?”

“They said yes.”

“Because who says no to that.”

“When does it start?”

“Tomorrow.”

“They want me there early.”

“That’s fast.”

“Yeah.”

A moment passed.

“I don’t think I’m supposed to say no.”

Allison swallowed.

“Will you still be around?”

“I’ll still be here.”

“Just... not like before.”

Allison stared at the screen until it dimmed and she had to tap it awake again.

Later, Allison opened her Notes app.

She stared at the blank page longer than usual, then typed:

Things that did not happen (today):

- The storm
- The power going out
- The trees moving
- Anyone explaining why

She added a separate line beneath the list:

Things that changed anyway:

- Evan’s schedule

She read the list once.

Then locked her phone.

She lay back on her bed and looked at the ceiling.

The crack was still there.

Same length. Same branching. Same pale certainty—an old, familiar pattern she could trace in her mind without looking.

She followed it with her eyes, counting the offshoots the way she always did when she needed something stable.

Not urgent.

Not dangerous.

Contained.

Outside, Alders Creek settled into a quiet evening. Power stayed on. Streets stayed clear. Everything intact.

Elsewhere, cleanup crews worked late into the night.

Allison closed her eyes.

Nothing bad had happened.

That was the problem.

Epilogue — Evan

The building didn't look like a school.

That was the first thing Evan noticed as he stood across the street, checking the address on his phone for the third time. It had no banners, no peeling posters taped to the windows, no clusters of students lingering outside like they weren't ready to go in yet. The glass reflected the sky cleanly, tinting the morning light just enough that he couldn't see much beyond it.

It didn't feel like a place you wandered into by accident.

The address matched anyway.

Inside, the air was cooler than he expected. Not cold—regulated. The kind of temperature you forgot about after a minute because it never changed. The floor didn't echo when he walked, and that threw him off more than it should have.

A woman at the front desk looked up as soon as he approached.

“Evan Hale?” she asked.

He nodded.

She handed him a badge with his name already printed on it. No clipboard slid across the counter. No forms to fill out. No question about emergency contacts or prior experience.

Just the badge.

“You're expected,” she said, smiling like that was reassuring.

Evan clipped it to his hoodie and followed the hallway she pointed him down. The walls were bare except for a few framed diagrams he didn't recognize at first glance. Everything smelled faintly of cleaner and warm electronics.

The lab space opened up suddenly, larger than anything at school. More stations than he could count without stopping. Screens already awake. Tools laid out in

careful order, like the room reset itself after every use.

Other students were already there.

They stood in small groups, talking easily, leaning against tables like they'd been doing this together for a while. A few glanced up when Evan came in, their eyes flicking briefly to his badge and then away again.

No one asked his name.

He chose an empty workstation near the edge and set his bag down slowly, aligning it with the leg of the table without really meaning to. The placement felt important, even though he couldn't have said why.

A man at the front of the room began speaking.

He introduced the program, the schedule, the expectations. His voice was calm, practiced. Everything was framed as opportunity—accelerated timelines, extended access, deeper focus. The kind of language Evan had heard before in videos and brochures, but never directed at him.

“You were selected,” the man said at one point, glancing down at a tablet. “Based on fit.”

Fit.

Evan wrote the word in the margin of his notebook before he realized he was doing it. The pen paused there, hovering, like it wanted clarification that wasn't coming.

When they broke into groups, Evan followed instructions exactly. He answered questions when asked. His hands moved on instinct when they started assembling components, muscle memory kicking in the way it always did when he was working on something that made sense.

He should have felt settled.

Instead, he kept checking the clock.

During the first break, he pulled out his phone.

No new messages.

He typed Allison's name into the search bar anyway, then erased it. She'd be in first period now. Or maybe study hall. Or somewhere else entirely, depending on how the day had been rearranged.

He tried to picture her desk.

The image wouldn't hold.

That bothered him more than it should have.

Someone dropped into the seat across from him, glancing at the half-assembled frame on his table.

"You from Alders Creek?" they asked.

"Yeah," Evan said.

"Oh." The other student nodded, slow. "Weird day yesterday."

"Yeah," Evan said again.

They shared a look that suggested agreement without specifics. Neither of them filled in the gap.

The morning blurred after that. Instructions stacked neatly on top of each other. Every time Evan finished one task, another was already waiting, already outlined, already queued up for him.

No downtime.

No idle moments.

No space to drift.

At lunch, he sat at a long table with people who seemed comfortable being there, talking about projects and timelines like this was the most natural place in the world to end up. Conversation stayed technical, efficient. Names didn't come up unless they were attached to work.

No one asked how he'd gotten here.

That question didn't seem to exist.

Evan checked his phone again.

Still nothing.

He considered sending a message. Something neutral. You okay? Or Did today feel strange to you too? The words sat there, unsent, like they might weigh too much if he let them go.

He locked the screen instead.

In the afternoon, they talked about what came next. Longer days. Transportation already arranged. Expectations framed as commitments, softened with smiles.

“It’s a lot,” someone said, like that made it easier. “But it’s worth it.”

Evan nodded along with everyone else.

On the ride home, the town came back into view slowly. Familiar houses. Familiar intersections. Everything intact. No branches down. No debris. No evidence that anything had ever been wrong.

Too intact.

When he got off at his stop, he stood there longer than necessary, watching the bus pull away. The quiet settled around him, complete and unbroken.

At home, his parents asked how it went.

“It was good,” he said, because that was the answer they were waiting for.

They relaxed immediately, like they’d been holding something in place all day and could finally let it go.

Upstairs, Evan dropped his bag on the floor and sat on the edge of his bed. The room felt smaller than it had that morning, like something had shifted its boundaries without telling him.

He checked his phone again.

Still nothing.

He typed a message before he could overthink it.

You home?

The typing bubble didn't appear.

Evan set the phone down beside him and stared at the wall as the afternoon light crept across it, slow and deliberate.

This was supposed to be a good thing.

He knew that. Everyone did.

But the thought that wouldn't let go was simple and quiet, settling in with the certainty of something already decided:

Allison hadn't been moved.

Everyone else had.

And whatever that meant, it felt like standing just outside a room where the door had closed gently—and knowing you weren't supposed to knock.